BOUNDARY GLOTTALS AND A'INGAE INFORMATION STRUCTURE: A MORPHOLOGICAL ARGUMENT FOR A DISCOURSE FEATURE GEOMETRY

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abstract I describe and analyze a pattern of morphosyntactically conditioned realization of a glottal stop morpheme *-ʔ* in A'ingae (or Cofán, an endangered Amazonian isolate, iso 639-3: `con`). The glottal stop *-ʔ* appears before three information structural morphemes—the new topic *-ta* new, contrastive topic *-ja* cntr, and exclusive focus *-yi* excl—when they attach directly to a TP, but not when they attach to other categories, such as DPs, CPs, or adverbs. I propose that the glottal stop (*-ʔ*) is a spell-out of T° conditioned by linear adjacency to a higher-order *discourse* feature [δ] (Mikkelsen, 2015; Bossi and Diercks, 2019) that dominates all the maximal information structural features in a feature geometry. By documenting an overt realization of a vocabulary item conditioned by [δ], the analysis provides new morphological evidence for a hierarchical arrangement of discourse features, and of Ā-feature geometry more broadly (e. g. Aravind, 2018; Baier, 2018; Baclawski, 2019). Additionally, by reducing the cross-linguistically unique distribution of the A'ingae *-ʔ* to independently motivated theoretical notions, it bears out a novel prediction of syntax-centric models of morphological grammar.

1 introduction

This paper describes and analyzes a pattern of morphosyntactically conditioned realization of the glottal stop *-ʔ* in A'ingae (or Cofán, an endangered Amazonian isolate, iso 639-3: `con`). A'ingae has four information structure (IS) morphemes: the new topic marker *-ta* new,[1] contrastive topic marker *-ja* cntr, exclusive focus marker *-yi* excl, and additive focus

1 The following glossing abbreviations have been used: 1 = first person, 2 = second person, 3 = third person, acc = accusative, acc2 = accusative 2, add = additive focus, adn = adnominal, adv = adverbializer, aimp = attenuated imperative, amb = ambulative, ana = anaphora, and = andative, anm = animate, appr = apprehensional, assr = assertive, attr = attributive, aug = augmentative, aux = auxiliary, bnd = bounded, C = complementizer, caus = causative, cntr = contrastive topic, dat = dative, dcs = deceased, def = definite, dem = demonstrative, dist = distal, drn = diurnal, ds = different subject, elat = elative, en = event nominalizer, excl = exclusive focus, flat = flat, foc = focus, frst = frustrative, h = human, hn = habitual nominalizer, hort = hortative, if = conditional, imp = imperative, ina = inanimate, inf = infinitive, ingr = ingressive, ins = instrumental, ipfv = imperfective, irr = irrealis, iter = iterative, lat = lateral, loc = locative, neg = negative, new = new topic, nn = negative nominalizer, op = operator, pa = predicative adjectivizer, pa2 = predicative adjectivizer 2, pass = passive, perm = permissive, pl = plural, pla = pluractional, plc = place, pls = plural subject, proh = prohibitive, prsp = prospective, purp = purposive, qnt = quantifier, rcpr = reciprocal, rel = relative, rmns = remansive, rnd = round, rprt = reportative, sa = similative adjectivizer, sg =

marker *-ʔkhe* add. The first three of these markers show a regular alternation between plain realizations (i. e. without a preceding glottal stop; *-ta*, *-ja*, *-yi*) and preglottalized realizations (*-ʔta*, *-ʔja*, *-ʔyi*), depending on the syntactic category of the base of attachment.

When the IS morphemes are attached to phrases of most syntactic categories, including—for example—noun phrases (1a), overtly subordinated clauses (1b), and adverbs (1c), no glottal stop is realized. However, when they are attached to infinitive verbs (2a), finite predicates in subordinate clauses (2b), or negative adverbial clauses (2c), they are realized as preglottalized. The key pattern is illustrated below with the new topic *-ta* new.[2] Anticipating my analysis, I gloss the glottal stop as a separate morpheme *-ʔ* T. The relevant IS markers (and the preceding glottal stop, when present) are underlined throughout the paper.[3]

(1) New topic *-ta* (*-nda*) realized as plain

a. attached to a noun phrase
yáya=ta =tsû tsámpi=ni já
dad=new =3 forest=loc go
"Dad went hunting." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

b. attached to an overtly subordinated verb
kháʔna-saʔne-nda =ngi íyûʔû
steal-appr-new =1 scold
"I advised (them) not to steal." (2024-05-31(1)_sia)

c. attached to an adverb
káni-nda =tsû án
yesterday-new =3 eat
"S/he ate yesterday." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

(2) New topic *-ʔta* (*-ʔnda*) realized with preglottalization

a. attached to an infinitive verb
án-ñe-ʔ-nda =ngi séʔpi
eat-inf-T-new =1 forbid
"I forbade eating." (2024-05-31(1)_sia)

singular, sn = subject nominalizer, ss = same subject, sta = spatial/temporal anaphora, T = tense, tent = tentative, thus = manner demonstrative, top = topic, vdm = verbal diminutive, ven = venitive, vpa = VP anaphor, wh = content interrogative, ynq = polar interrogative.

2 A'ingae shows iterative progressive nasal spreading (as well as non-iterative regressive nasalization) (Dąbkowski, 2024a; Sanker and AnderBois, 2024; Bennett et al., t.a.). Consequently, *-ta* new, *-ja* cntr, and *-yi* excl surface as *-nda* new, *-jan* cntr, and *-ñi* excl after nasal vowels. This oral-nasal alternation is orthogonal to the morphosyntactically conditioned preglottalization under scrutiny.

3 Many functional morphemes, including the four IS markers under investigation, can attach to constituents of various categories, including noun phrases—in which case they appear at their very right edge, regardless of phrase-internal word order—as well as verb phrases and adverbs—in which case they always appear on the head of the phrase, i. e. the verb or adverb itself. Correspondingly, I represent them as either clitics or affixes. This distinction does not, in itself, have any morphophonological correlates (Dąbkowski, 2021c, 2024b), nor does it correlate directly with the realization or non-realization of *-ʔ* T.

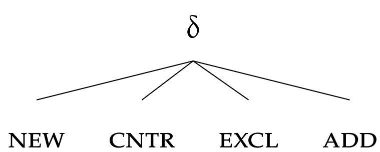
b. ATTACHED TO A FINITE PREDICATE
sése *jí-ʔ-ta* *=tsû án-ña*
papagayo come-T-NEW =3 eat-IRR
"If the papagayo comes, it will eat." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

c. ATTACHED TO A NEGATIVE ADVERBIAL CLAUSE
setsa-yé-mbe-ʔ-ta *=tsû kánse*
infect-PASS-ADV.NEG-T-NEW =3 live
"S/he does not get sick." (2025-07-17(1)_mll)

The four markers under discussion (*-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, *-yi* EXCL, *-ʔkhe* ADD) form a natural class—they all encode information structural meanings and attach to the same range of constituents. (For more on their similarities, see Section 3.) As such, the realization of *-ʔ* T should be seen not as conditioned by a set of unrelated morphemes, but rather attributed to some morphosyntactic property that all of them have in common.

In Section 6, I will propose that the glottal stop *-ʔ* is a realization of the T-head conditioned by linear adjacency to IS morphology. The conditioning environment is formalized as a higher-order *discourse* feature [δ] (Mikkelsen, 2015; Bossi and Diercks, 2019), which is entailed by all the more specific IS features, including new topic [NEW], contrastive topic [CNTR], exclusive focus [EXCL], and additive focus [ADD]. The proposed feature geometry is visualized in (3).

(3) DISCOURSE FEATURE GEOMETRY



Since all the information structural markers inherit from [δ], they all satisfy the T-head's conditioning environment. However, if any phonologically overt material appears between the T-head and the IS marker, the realization of the glottal stop *-ʔ* is blocked (Embick, 2010, 2015). A structural schema representing the conditions for the realization of *-ʔ* is given in (4). (Conversely, in all the cases where *-ʔ* does not appear, these conditions are not met—i. e. there is no T-head directly adjacent to an IS marker.)

(4) ʔ-REALIZATION SCHEMA

right edge of TP ↘
[*root* ... **-ʔ**]$_{\mathrm{TP}}$ *-sfx*$_{[\delta]}$
↑ ↑ ↖ information structural morpheme
T° no overt material intervening

The implications of this analysis are twofold. First, in previous literature, the notion of *discourse differentiation* (Mikkelsen, 2015), formalized by Bossi and Diercks (2019) as a superordinate discourse feature [δ], has been motivated by word-order facts in Kipsigis (Nilo-Saharan, Kenya; Bossi and Diercks, 2019) and Danish (North Germanic, Denmark; Mikkelsen, 2015). The present study focuses on patterns of allomorphy in the domain of A'ingae information structural markers. By showing that all the A'ingae IS morphemes pattern alike in triggering allomorphy of the T-head, the current paper provides novel morphological evidence for a hierarchical arrangement of discourse features (with [δ] inherited by the maximal topic and focus features), and of Ā-feature geometry more broadly (e. g. Aravind, 2018; Baier, 2018; Baclawski, 2019).

Second, the distribution of *-ʔ* T is typologically unusual—the suffix realizes an abstract morphosyntactic position when adjacent to a marker drawn from a semantically defined set. To the best of my knowledge, no other language has been described as having morphological exponents with comparable characteristics. Nevertheless, the analysis in Section 6 will rely only on (a combination of) previously motivated solutions (e. g. Shlonsky, 1997; Mikkelsen, 2015; Bossi and Diercks, 2019), without introducing any new theoretical devices. This reduction of a cross-linguistically unique pattern to independently needed theoretical atoms shows that the distribution of the A'ingae *-ʔ* T can not only be accounted for, but is in fact predicted by syntax-centric models of word-internal morphological structure such as Distributed Morphology (DM) (e. g. Halle and Marantz, 1993, 1994; Embick and Noyer, 2007; Embick, 2010, 2015).

The rest of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 provides background on the language and summarizes some relevant aspects of its grammar. Section 3 introduces the A'ingae four discourse markers and discusses their uses. Section 4 lays out the structure of A'ingae predicates. Section 5 describes the patterns of *ʔ*-realization observed before the IS markers, and motivates some analytical choices made along the way. Section 6 presents an account of the patterns formalized in DM. Section 7 briefly discusses alternative, rejected proposals. Section 8 recapitulates the findings and concludes.

2 LANGUAGE BACKGROUND

A'ingae (or Cofán, ISO 639-3: `con`) is an endangered Amazonian language spoken by ca. 1,500 Cofán people in the northeast Ecuadorian province of Sucumbíos and the southern Colombian department of Putumayo. The language remains classified as an isolate (AnderBois, Emlen, et al., 2019), despite some previous (mostly geography-driven) claims to the contrary (e. g. in Rivet, 1924, 1952; Ruhlen, 1987).

A'ingae remains relatively vital, with approximately five out of six children acquiring it as their first language (Pomilia, 2025). Sociocultural attitudes surrounding A'ingae are uniformly positive, and the speakers welcome projects aimed at documenting and preserving the language (Dąbkowski, 2021a).

A'ingae syllable structure can be schematized as (C)V(V)(ʔ)—onsets are optional, nuclei are maximally diphthongal, and glottal stops are the only licit coda. Additionally, glottal stops are disallowed word-finally. The present paper uses the practical orthography with two deviations: glottal stops are represented with the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) symbol (ʔ), not apostrophe (ʹ), and stress is marked with the acute accent (´). For more on the A'ingae orthography, see Repetti-Ludlow et al. (2019), Fischer and Hengeveld (2023), and Dąbkowski (2024a).

A'ingae is a highly agglutinating, exclusively suffixing, and encliticizing language. The vast majority of the language's functional morphemes are -CV or -ʔCV monosyllables (the preglottalization, if present, is parsed as the coda of the preceding syllable); most of the language's glottal stop tokens come from preglottalized suffixes. There are many lexically contrastive morphemes that constitute plain–preglottalized minimal pairs, e. g. the classifier for flat objects *-je* FLAT vs. imperfective *-ʔje* IPFV, the accusative *=ma* ACC vs. frustrative *-ʔma* FRST, or the dative *=nga* DAT vs. andative *-ʔnga* AND. The glottal stop *-ʔ* T discussed in this paper is different in that it is a separate morpheme. (Notwithstanding, out of terminological convenience, I often refer to the sequences of *-ta*, *-ja*, *-yi* and *-ʔta*, *-ʔja*, *-ʔyi* as—respectively—plain and preglottalized realizations of NEW, CNTR, and EXCL.)

The A'ingae default word order is subject–object–verb (SOV), although in matrix clauses, it is largely free. (Co)subordinate clauses are predominantly verb-final (for some exceptions, see Dąbkowski, 2025c, 2026a). The language has nominative-accusative morphosyntactic alignment; subjects are unmarked and direct objects are marked with one of two accusative clitics: *=ma* ACC or *=ve* ACC2. A'ingae supports robust pro-drop; any of the clausal arguments may be dropped if inferrable from context.

The data presented in this paper comes from published materials written originally in A'ingae and fieldwork elicitation conducted by the author. The elicitation tasks included translating between A'ingae and Spanish as well as grammaticality judgments. All the data drawn from previous publications are cited as such.[4] All the fieldwork data has been deposited in the California Language Archive (CLA) as Dąbkowski (2020) and cited with a `YYYY-MM-DD(N)_ccc`identifier.[5]

Previous descriptive work on the language includes Fischer and Hengeveld (2023) and Hengeveld and Fischer (in prep.) and chapters in Dąbkowski (2025c). Aspects of the language's phonetics and phonology have been analyzed by Repetti-Ludlow et al. (2019), Repetti-Ludlow (2021), Dąbkowski (2023c, 2024a), Sanker and AnderBois (2024), and Dąbkowski (2025a,b). Various topics in the language's morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics, and their interfaces have been discussed by e. g. Fischer (2007), Fischer and van Lier (2011), Hengeveld and Fischer (2018), Morvillo and AnderBois (2022), AnderBois,

4 Since glottalization is not reliably represented in written A'ingae (and stress is often not represented at all), I have double-checked the relevant data with native speakers. At times, my consultants improved on the word choice or corrected some of the grammatical forms. In all such cases, the reported data reflect the choices and judgments of my consultants, not the original medium.

5 `YYYY` stands for the year, `MM` — the month, `DD` — the day, `N` — the number of the consecutive elicitation session conducted on a given day, and `ccc` — the three-letter consultant name abbreviation. File names of the CLA-deposited materials often also contain keywords, briefly summarizing the contents of the session.

Altshuler, and Silva (2023), Zheng and AnderBois (2023), Dąbkowski and AnderBois (2024), Kalpande (2024), and Dąbkowski and AnderBois (2026).

For reasons of space, many of the empirical patterns are illustrated with a limited number of sentences. For additional examples and further descriptive facts related to the A'ingae topic and focus markers, see Section A.

3 A PRIMER ON DISCOURSE MARKERS

A'ingae has four morphemes dedicated to encoding discourse-related information: two encoding topichood (Section 3.1), and two encoding focus (Section 3.2).

3.1 *Topic markers*

The topic of a sentence is the entity that the sentence is intuitively "about." This is to say, the topic is a referent that the rest of the sentence comments on (Krifka, 2008). A'ingae distinguishes two types of overtly marked topics: the new topic *-ta* NEW and the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR. The semantic contributions of the markers are often not reflected in translations to Spanish or English. Moreover, in most sentences, *-ta* NEW and *-ja* CNTR can be removed without resulting in ungrammaticality. Below, I discuss some prototypical uses of the two topic markers.

The new topic marker *-ta* NEW indicates that the referent was not previously present in the discourse. For example, the marker often appears on individuals that are introduced for the first time (5).

(5) REFERENT INTRODUCED WITH -TA NEW
[seeing a city in the distance for the first time:]
jú-va tútu-a=ta =ti patû-ndûʔndû
DIST-DEM white-ADN=NEW =YNQ rock-beach
"Is that white over there a rocky beach?"
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 24; `2025-08-26(1)_mll`)

The above observation is supported by native speakers' metalinguistic judgments. For example, when topichood is forced with a simple "what about" question, answers with the new topic *-ta* NEW (6b) are preferred over information structurally unmarked (6a) and contrastive topic *ja*-marked answers (6c).[6]

6 A constituent marked with the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR cannot be directly followed by a second position clitic. As a consequence, for example, in (6c), the clitic is shifted down to the following constituent. This is further discussed in Section A.1.

(6) ANSWER TO "WHAT ABOUT." *TA*-MARKING PREFERRED
[A: What about Edison?]
a. DISCOURSE-UNMARKED RESPONSE
#B: *Édison =tsû yúku cháthû=ʔsû já*
Edison =3 yoco cut=SN go
b. NEW TOPIC-MARKED RESPONSE
B: *Édison=nda =tsû yúku cháthû=ʔsû já*
Edison=NEW =3 yoco cut=SN go
c. CONTRASTIVE TOPIC-MARKED RESPONSE
#B: *Édison=jan yúku cháthû=ʔsû =tsû já*
Edison=CNTR yoco cut=SN =3 go
"Edison left to cut some yoco." (`2025-08-22(1)_mll`)

The new topic marker *-ta* NEW is also commonly observed on "stage-setting" constituents, which specify the time or location of an event. In such contexts, speakers explicitly judge *ta*-marked phrases (7b) as better than the unmarked (7a) and *ja*-marked ones (7c).

(7) STAGE SETTING: *TA*-MARKING PREFERRED
[beginning of a chapter:]
a. DISCOURSE-UNMARKED GROUND
#tayúpi =tsû injántshi Saráru kánse-ʔfa Avárícu náʔen=ni
long ago =3 many giant otter live-PLS Aguarico river=LOC
b. NEW TOPIC-MARKED GROUND
tayúpi-ta =tsû injántshi Saráru kánse-ʔfa Avárícu náʔen=ni
long ago-NEW =3 many giant otter live-PLS Aguarico river=LOC
c. CONTRASTIVE TOPIC-MARKED GROUND
#tayúpi-ja injántshi Saráru =tsû kánse-ʔfa Avárícu náʔen=ni
long ago-CNTR many giant otter =3 live-PLS Aguarico river=LOC
"In the past, many otters lived in the Aguarico River."
(based on Lucitante et al., 2011, pp. 48–49; `2025-08-22(1)_mll`)

The same judgments obtain when a discourse marker is preceded by the glottal stop *-ʔ* T. For example, when bringing a new subject matter up for the first time, the new topic marker *-ta* NEW (8b) on an infinitival subject is preferred to null marking (8a) and *ja*-marking (8c).

(8) NEW SUBJECT MATTER: *ʔTA*-MARKING PREFERRED
[Speaker is on stage, giving a talk about the benefits of eating vegetables. He starts by saying:]
a. DISCOURSE-UNMARKED SUBJECT
#tetáchu=ma án-ñe =tsû kínse-tshi
vegetable=ACC eat-INF =3 health-PA

b. NEW TOPIC-MARKED SUBJECT
tetáchu=ma án-ñe-ʔ-nda =tsû kínse-tshi
vegetable=ACC eat-INF-T-NEW =3 health-PA

c. CONTRASTIVE TOPIC-MARKED SUBJECT
#*tetáchu=ma án-ñe-ʔ-jan kínse-tshi =tsû*
vegetable=ACC eat-INF-T-CNTR health-PA =3

"Eating vegetables is healthy." (`2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

The contrastive topic marker *-ja* CNTR is used in the presence of alternative topics in the discourse, especially when information about different individuals is overtly or covertly juxtaposed. For example, it may be used on a subject which contrasts with other discourse participants in whether they took part in some activity (9). In comparable circumstances, English may distinguish the contrasted constituent prosodically.

(9) SUBJECT PROPERTY CONTRASTED WITH *-JA* CNTR
[dialogue between A and B:
A: Who all went?
B: Dad, my uncle, and my older brother.]
A: *mínga?u-si =ki ké=ja já-mbi*
why-DS =2 2SG=CNTR go-NEG
"Why didn't *you* go?"
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 9; `2025-08-26(1)_mll`)

Another use of the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR can be seen in (10). The paragraph's main question under discussion (von Stutterheim and Klein, 1989; van Kuppevelt, 1995) is: *what are tapirs like?* The subquestions about different body part of the tapir, such as *what are tapirs' noses like?* (10a) and *what are tapirs' feet like?* (10b), receive answers with different body parts explicitly marked with the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR.

(10) SUBQUESTIONS CONTRASTED WITH *-JA* CNTR
[description of a tapir: "Tapirs live in the jungle. They frequent salt licks ...]

a. *tsá=ta =tsû tíse tsúfaʔthû=ja biá-ʔ-a* ...
ANA=NEW =3 3SG nose=CNTR long-PA2-ADN
"Their noses are long ... "

b. *túyaʔkaen tíse tsûʔthe=ja táʔe-tshi*
and 3SG foot=CNTR hard-PA
"And their feet are hard."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 33; `2025-08-26(1)_mll`)

These patterns are, again, confirmed by the speakers' metalinguistic judgements. When different individuals are contrasted with one another, *ja*-marking (11c) is preferred over *ta*-marking (11b) or lack of marking (11a). Below, this is illustrated with a question-and-answer pair, where the answer explicitly juxtaposes two people.

(11) JUXTAPOSED PROPERTIES: *JA*-MARKING PREFERRED
[A: Do your children work hard?]

a. DISCOURSE-UNMARKED TOPICS
#B: *ña únkeʔnge =tsû pánsheʔen semá-ñe atésû; ña dû́tshiʔye =tsû nuéʔsû*
1SG daughter =3 a lot work-INF know 1SG son =3 be lazy

b. *TA*-MARKED TOPICS
#B: *ña únkeʔnge=ta =tsû pánsheʔen semá-ñe atésû; ña dû́tshiʔye=ta =tsû nuéʔsû*
1SG daughter=NEW =3 a lot work-INF know 1SG son=NEW =3 be lazy

c. *JA*-MARKED TOPICS
B: *ña únkeʔnge=ja pánsheʔen =tsû semá-ñe atésû; ña dû́tshiʔye=ja nuéʔsû =tsû*
1SG daughter=CNTR a lot =3 work-INF know 1SG son=CNTR be lazy =3

"My daughter works a lot; my son is lazy." (`2025-08-26(1)_mll`)

Similarly, in narrative contexts, when attention is drawn to an opposition between two (or more) entities, *ja*-marking on the contrasted participants is judged as more felicitous than a lack of marking or *ta*-marking (12b, 12c).

(12) CONTRASTED PARTICIPANTS: *JA*-MARKING PREFERRED
[beginning of the story *Peccary Demons:* "Four hunters went deep into the forest in search of game, and they lost their way. As it was about to get dark, two of them started to set up camp, and the other two left to look for food ...]

a. *tsá-ʔka-en já-pa shishithúshe=ma áthe-pa*
ANA-SA-ADV go-SS chameleon=ACC see-SS
"(The two hunters who were looking for food) came upon a chameleon ... "

b. *fáeʔkhu{#=∅, #=ta, =ja} índi-pa fíthi~ʔthi*
one=∅, =NEW, =CNTR catch-SS kill~PLA
"One (of them) grabbed (and started) killing (it) ... "

c. *tsá=ʔma fáesû{#=∅, #=ta, =ja} phuráen-mbi*
ANA=FRST other=∅, =NEW, =CNTR touch-NEG
"but (the) other (one) didn't touch (it)."
(based on Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 123; `2025-08-26(1)_mll`)

The same felicity conditions hold when *-ja* CNTR is preglottalized. For example, when an activity is contrasted, a verb marked with *-ja* CNTR (13c) is preferred over its unmarked (13a) and *ta*-marked (13b) variants.

(13) CONTRASTED ACTIVITIES: *ʔJA*-MARKING PREFERRED

a. DISCOURSE-UNMARKED ACTIVITY
#séʔpi-ʔchu =tsû án-ñe; séʔpi-ʔchu-mbi =tsû kû́ʔi-ye
prohibit-EN =3 eat-INF; prohibit-EN-NEG =3 drink-INF

b. *TA*-MARKED ACTIVITY
#*séʔpi-ʔchu =tsû án-ñe; kû́ʔi-ye-ʔ-ta =tsû séʔpi-ʔchu-mbi*
prohibit-EN =3 eat-INF; drink-INF-T-NEW =3 prohibit-EN-NEG
c. *JA*-MARKED ACTIVITY
séʔpi-ʔchu =tsû án-ñe; séʔpi-ʔchu-mbi =tsû kû́ʔi-ye-ʔ-ja
prohibit-EN =3 eat-INF; prohibit-EN-NEG =3 drink-INF-T-CNTR
"Eating is prohibited; *drinking* isn't." (`2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

The felicity conditions on the discourse unmarked, *ta*-marked, and *ja*-marked constituents can be further illustrated by seeing how the specifics of a situation may affect the way a speaker chooses to introduce themselves. When asked to introduce themselves out of the blue (with no additional context provided), an information structurally unmarked response is felicitous (14a). A *ta*-marked first-person subject can be used in an introduction at the beginning of a conference talk (i. e. when one is shifting to a new topic) (14b). And lastly, while in a group setting and after hearing out other people's introductions, one may opt to set oneself apart with the contrastive *ja*-marking (14c).

(14) INTRODUCTIONS
a. UNMARKED INTRODUCTION
[A: Who are you?]
B: *Marcélo =ngi*
Marcelo =1
"I'm Marcelo." (`2025-08-22(1)_mll`)
b. *TA*-MARKED INTRODUCTION
[Speaker is at a conference. He is about to give a talk about his work in the Indigenous Cofán Guard in front of a large crowd. He goes on stage and introduces himself:]
ñá=nda =ngi Marcélo
1SG=NEW =1 Marcelo
"I'm Marcelo." (`2025-08-22(1)_mll`)
c. *JA*-MARKED INTRODUCTION
[Speaker and others sit in a circle at a meeting. Everyone in the group introduces themself. First, one person says "I'm Maksymilian," another one says "I'm Edison," another one "I'm Leidy." Then, the speaker introduces himself:]
ñá=jan Marcélo =ngi
1SG=CNTR Marcelo =1
"I'm Marcelo." (`2025-08-22(1)_mll`)

Finally, I note that *ta*- and *ja*-marked constituents are infelicitous as fragment answers to WH-questions (15). This is consistent with their topic status (which is incompatible with the focus information of fragment answers; Aissen, 2023).

(15) NO TOPIC MARKING IN FRAGMENT ANSWERS
[A: Who came?]
B: *ña ántian{=∅, #=nda, #=jan}*
1SG brother=∅, =NEW, =CNTR
"My brother." (`2025-08-21(1)_mll`)

3.2 *Focus markers*

Now, I briefly discuss the A'ingae focus markers. Focus indicates that in addition to the referent denoted by the marked phrase, other entities are also relevant to the interpretation of the sentence (Krifka, 2008, p. 247). A'ingae has two focus morphemes: the exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL and the additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD. The exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL indicates that a proposition holds of the marked entity to the exclusion of alternatives; it can often be translated as "only" (16a), "just," "very (same)," "as soon as" (16b), or with cleft constructions.

(16) USES OF THE EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL (also see Section A.2)
a. *tsá-ʔka-en pá-ʔfa-si khuánifae tsandié=ndekhû=yi khûshá-ʔfa*
ANA-SA-ADV die-PLS-DS three man=PL.H=EXCL survive-PLS
"When they thus died, only three men were spared."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 37; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)
b. *panzá-ʔ-yi-ta =ngi buthû̂-ya*
hunt-T-EXCL-NEW =1 run-IRR
"As soon as I catch it, I will run." (Dąbkowski, 2026a; `2025-08-12(1)_jxm`)

The additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD indicates that the proposition holds of the marked entity in addition to some alternatives; it can often be translated as "too," "as well," "also" (17a), "and," or "even (though)," and—in negative polarity contexts—as "either" or "(not) even" (17b). (The additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD is analyzed as underlyingly preglottalized, so the overt presence or absence of *-ʔ* T can never be observed before it. See Section 6 for the full analysis.)

(17) USES OF THE ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD (also see Section A.2)
a. *tsá=ma áthe-pa fáesû=ma=ʔkhe áthe*
ANA=ACC see-SS other=ACC=ADD see
"When (he) looked, (he) also saw another one."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 38; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)
b. *tsá-ʔma tsé-ki kúse ni fae ávû=ve=yi=ʔkhe índi-ʔfa-mbi =ngi*
ANA-FRST STA-DRN night neither one fish=ACC2=EXCL=ADD catch-PLS-NEG =1
"But that night we did not catch even a single fish."
(John 21:3; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

The exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL may be followed by the additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD (18a), or by either topic marker (18b-c). The additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD may be followed by the new topic

-ta NEW (18d). The two topic markers *-ta* NEW and *-ja* CNTR are mutually incompatible (18e-f). These combinatorial possibilities are summarized in Table 1.[7] For full sentences demonstrating co-occurrence possibilities among the A'ingae discourse markers, see Section A.2.

(18) COMPATIBILITY AMONG DISCOURSE MARKERS (Dąbkowski, 2026a)

a. *ávû=ve=yi=ʔkhe*
fish=ACC2=EXCL=ADD
(2024-06-07(1)_mll)

b. *kánse-ʔfa-ʔ-yi-ta*
live-PLS-T-EXCL-NEW
(2024-06-07(1)_mll)

c. *áʔi=yi=ja*
person=EXCL=CNTR
(2024-06-07(1)_mll)

d. *ké=ʔkhe=ta*
2SG=ADD=NEW
(2024-06-07(1)_mll)

e. **ávû=ta=ja*
fish=NEW=CNTR
(2026-03-09(1)_jxm)

f. **ávû=ja=ta*
fish=CNTR=NEW
(2026-03-09(1)_jxm)

1ST ↓ / 2ND →	*-yi* EXCL	*-ʔkhe* ADD	*-ta* NEW	*-ja* CNTR
-yi- EXCL	—	*-yiʔkhe*	*-yita*	*-yija*
-ʔkhe- ADD	✗	—	*-ʔkheta*	✗
-ta- NEW	✗	✗	—	✗
-ja- CNTR	✗	✗	✗	—

Table 1: Co-occurrence among the A'ingae information structural markers

4 A PRIMER ON PREDICATES

Most of the core data in Section 5 will pertain to the realization or non-realization of *-ʔ* T on predicates. As such, in this section, I present the basics of A'ingae predicate morphosyntax, including both verbal and nominal predicates.

4.1 *Verbal predicates*

A'ingae predicates can vary greatly in morphological complexity. On one end, the head of a finite TP may consist of a bare root. On the other end, a plethora of grammatical categories can be expressed on a verb by means of suffixation (Dąbkowski, 2021c, 2024b). An example of a highly inflected verb is presented in (19).

(19) VERBAL PREDICATE STRUCTURE

[[[[*kufi* *-án* $]_{\text{VceP}}$ *-ʔjen* *-ngi* $]_{\text{AspP}}$ *-ʔfa* *-mbi* $]_{\text{TP}}$ *-ʔni* *-nda* $]_{\text{CP}}$
play -CAUS -IPFV -VEN -PLS -NEG -IF.DS -NEW

"now$_{\text{NEW}}$, if$_{\text{IF}}$ (they$_{\text{PLS}}$) do not$_{\text{NEG}}$ come$_{\text{VEN}}$ to be$_{\text{IPFV}}$ making$_{\text{CAUS}}$ play, (someone else$_{\text{DS}}$) ..." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

7 Fischer and Hengeveld (2023) also report that the additive focus marker *-ʔkhe* ADD may be followed by the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR. Since I have not been able to corroborate this combination, I do not report it here.

The morphological template of the A'ingae verb is given in Table 2. The verbal root is at the bottom, and the subsequent morphosyntactic slots appear above the root, mimicking the orientation of a syntax tree.

The A'ingae suffixes are grouped into four major functional projection domains. First, the voice domain (VceP) includes the causative *-ña/-an/-en* CAUS (i), reciprocal *-khu* RCPR (iii), and passive *-ye* PASS (iv).[8] The pluractional reduplicant/infix *-ʔσ/‹ʔ›* PLA (ii) comes after the causative *-ña/-an/-en* CAUS. (For more on *-ʔσ/‹ʔ›* PLA, see Dąbkowski, 2023a, 2024a.)

Second, the verbal inflectional domain (AspP) encompasses the aspectual suffixes (v), including the imperfective *-ʔje* IPFV, ingressive *-ji* INGR, verbal diminutive *-kha* VDM, iterative *-ʔñakha* ITER, remansive *-chu* RMNS, and prospective *-yi/-ña* PRSP, as well as three associated motion suffixes (vi): the venitive *-ʔngi* VEN, andative *-ʔnga* AND, and ambulative *-kan* AMB.

Third, the situation-level domain (TP) is comprised of markers for (vii) subject number (plural *-ʔfa* PLS), (viii) reality (irrealis *-ya* IRR), finiteness (infinitive *-ye* INF), and (ix) polarity (negative *-mbi* NEG and negative adverbial *-mbe* ADV.NEG).

A'ingae has no overt verbal morphology devoted to encoding tense. Nonetheless, following Shlonsky (1997, p. 3), I assume that every clause—by definition—contains the TP layer, so TP is universally present in all languages, including A'ingae (x). In Section 6, I will propose that the glottal stop under investigation *-ʔ* is in fact a spell-out of the T-head when linearly adjacent to an IS marker.[9]

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8 Some previous descriptions of the A'ingae verbal template (e. g. Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2026b) single out the causative morpheme *-ña/-an/-en* CAUS as the head of a separate verbal categorizing projection *v*P, and lump the other two voices (*-khu* RCPR, *-ye* PASS) with the aspectual suffixes under AspP. Dąbkowski's (2024b, 2026b) presentation has a phonological motivation—there is phonological evidence that *v*P is a phase, but there is no comparable evidence for VceP being a phase. Since the present paper is concerned only with morphosyntax, not phonology, I have opted here for a more semantically transparent presentation of the verbal template.

9 Some language-internal evidence supporting the existence of TP as both a syntactosemantic and a spell-out domain in A'ingae comes from an interaction between nominalization height and the (non-)application of morphophonological effects (i). When attaching low, many of the A'ingae nominalizers (including the bounded space classifier *-khû* BND) normally override the base's glottalization and assign stress to the syllable which precedes them (ia). However, when attaching high, the otherwise regular overriding is blocked (ib).

(i) STRESS/GLOTTALIZATION × NOMINALIZATION HEIGHT ON /*PÚʔTA-EN*/ (from Dąbkowski, 2026b)

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ OVERWRITTEN

tíse [putá-en]$_{vP}$-khû =ni =ngi jáyi

3SG pierce-CAUS-BND =LOC =1 going

"I'm going his/her shooting range." (compatible with: S/he owns it, but has never shot a gun him/herself.) (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED

[tíse [púʔta-en]$_{vP}$]$_{TP}$-khû =ni =ngi jáyi

3SG pierce-CAUS-BND =LOC =1 going

"I'm going to the room where s/he shot (lit. made (a gun) pierce)."
not: "*I'm going his/her shooting range." (S/he owns it, but has never shot a gun him/herself.) (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

MATRIX CLAUSAL CLITICS (CP)

(xvi) SUBJECT PERSON: *=ngi* 1, *=ki* 2, *=tsû* 3

(xv) SENTENCE-LEVEL: *=te* RPRT, *=ti* YNQ

CLAUSE-LEVEL SUFFIXES (CP)

(xiv) TOPIC: *-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR

(xiii) ADDITIVITY: *-ʔkhe* ADD

(xii) EXCLUSIVITY: *-yi* EXCL

(xi) CLAUSE TYPE

MATRIX: *-ja* IMP, *-kha* AIMP, *-ʔse* PERM, *-jama* PROH, *-ʔya* ASSR

COSUBORDINATE: *-pa* SS, *-si* DS

SUBORDINATE: *-saʔne* APPR, *-khen* TENT, (*-ʔa* IF.SS,) *-ʔni* IF.DS, *-ʔma* FRST

SITUATION-LEVEL SUFFIXES (TP)

(x) TENSE: (-ʔ T)

(ix) POLARITY: *-mbi* NEG, *-mbe* ADV.NEG

(viii) REALITY/FINITENESS: *-ya* IRR, *-ye* INF

(vii) SUBJECT NUMBER: *-ʔfa* PLS

VERBAL INFLECTIONAL SUFFIXES (AspP)

(vi) ASSOC MOTION: *-ʔngi* VEN, *-ʔnga* AND, *-kan* AMB

(v) ASPECT: *-ʔje* IPFV, *-ji* INGR, *-kha* VDM, *-ʔñakha* ITER, *-chu* RMNS, *-yi/-ña* PRSP

VOICE SUFFIXES (VceP)

(iv) PASSIVE: *-ye* PASS

(iii) RECIPROCAL: *-khu* RCPR

(ii) PLURACTIONAL: *-ʔσ/‹ʔ›* PLA

(i) CAUSATIVE: *-ña/-an/-en* CAUS

VERBAL ROOT (√P)

(0) VERBAL ROOT: √

Table 2: Morphological template of the A'ingae verb (building on Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025c,d)

Dąbkowski (2026b) proposes that high nominalizations contain the TP layer, which blocks the overriding of stress and glottalization. The presence of the TP layer also has implications for the clause's temporal semantics. For example, eventive TPs typically receive past interpretations (ib). Low nominalizations lack the TP layer, resulting in semantics compatible with object-like (rather than situation-like) interpretations (ia). For further exploration of these patterns and their analysis, see Dąbkowski (2026b).

Fourth, the clause-level domain (CP) hosts suffixes that can be categorized as appearing on either matrix (*-ja* IMP, *-kha* AIMP, *-ʔse* PERM, *-jama* PROH, *-ʔya* ASSR), cosubordinate (*-pa* SS, *-si* DS), or subordinate clauses (*-saʔne* APPR, *-khen* TENT, *-ʔa* IF.SS, *-ʔni* IF.DS, *-ʔma* FRST).

A'ingae subordinate and cosubordinate clauses can be inflected for features such as subject plurality (*-ʔfa* PLS; 20a-20b), reality status (irrealis *-ya* IRR; 20a), polarity (negative *-mbi* NEG; 20a), and finiteness (infinitive *-ye* INF; 20b). Below, these morphemes are underlined. This shows that subordinate clauses consist of at least the TP layer (and also may have an overt or phonologically null CP layer).

(20) SUBORDINATE CLAUSE INFLECTION

a. FINITE SUBORDINATE CLAUSE
kúfe-ʔje-ʔfa-ya-mbi-ʔma =tsû avûjá-tshi-ʔfa-ya
play-IPFV-PLS-IRR-FRST =3 rejoice-PA-PLS-IRR
"Even if they are not playing, they will be happy." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

b. INFINITIVE SUBORDINATE CLAUSE
mandá-ʔfa =tsû sumbú-ʔfa-ye
order-PLS =3 leave-PLS-INF
"They told them to leave." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

Cosubordinate and subordinate clauses can then additionally be marked for discourse information with the new topic *-ta* NEW, contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR, exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL, and/or additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD. I assume that the clause-type markers (xi) are C-heads, and the discourse morphemes (xii-xiv) are adjuncts that can attach to different syntactic categories without changing the category label.

If appearing towards the beginning of a sentence, most verbs can then be followed by second-position clitics (xv-xvi), including the reportative *=te* RPRT, the polar interrogative *=ti* YNQ, as well as the first *=ngi* 1, second *=ki* 2, or third *=tsû* 3 person subject clitic. (Since second-position clitics are phonologically integrated with the verb (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025c), they are included here, despite technically not being a part of the verb's morphological template.)

In Table 2, the morphemes given in parentheses are overt feature-bundle realizations observed in specific syntactic contexts (to be discussed in Section 5). In other environments, those same feature bundles are phonologically null. Also note that Table 2 captures the relative order of verbal morphemes, but does not represent additional co-occurrence restrictions. For co-occurrence restrictions among the discourse markers, see Table 1. For co-occurrence restrictions among the TP morphemes, see Section 6.

4.2 *Non-verbal predicates*

Finally, I touch on the morphosyntax of non-verbal predicates. The first two projections (VceP and AspP) shown in Table 2 are exclusive to morphological verbs. This is to say, the voice, aspect, and associated motion suffixes can appear only on verbal heads.

The morphemes hosted by the latter two projections (TP and CP), on the other hand, can occur on both verbal and non-verbal predicates, including noun phrases and adjectives.[10] A'ingae lacks a copula verb; as such, the TP and CP morphemes attach directly to non-verbal predicates. An example of a noun phrase (with a bare possessor and the inflectional plural clitic *=ndekhû* PL.H) functioning as a predicate is given in (21). IS morphemes behave in similar ways on verbal and non-verbal predicates. As such, in the rest of the paper, I group and discuss them together.

(21) NOMINAL PREDICATE STRUCTURE

tíseʔpa [[[*ña yayá =ndekhû*]$_{\text{DP}}$ *=ʔfa =mbi*]$_{\text{TP}}$ *=ʔni =nda*]$_{\text{CP}}$

3PL 1SG dad =PL.H =PLS =NEG =IF.DS =NEW

"now$_{\text{NEW}}$, if$_{\text{IF}}$ they$_{\text{3PL}}$ are$_{\text{PLS}}$ not$_{\text{NEG}}$ my$_{\text{1SG}}$ parents$_{\text{PL.H}}$, (someone else$_{\text{DS}}$) ..."

(2024-06-18(1)_mll)

5 THE DISTRIBUTION OF -ʔ T

The glottal stop under investigation -*ʔ* T appears only before discourse markers and only in certain morphosyntactic contexts. As such, in this section, I present and discuss the discourse markers as attached to constituents of various categories, and document in which configurations the glottal stop -*ʔ* T precedes them. First, I briefly go over non-predicates (§5.1). Then, I look at subordinate predicates of various types (§5.2–6).

5.1 *Non-predicates*

The A'ingae IS morphemes are most often observed on arguments and adjuncts of various kinds, including e. g. bare nouns (22a, 22d), case marked phrases (22b), adjectives (22b), and adverbs (22c).

(22) PLAIN REALIZATION ON NON-PREDICATES (also see Section A.2)

a. BARE NOUN + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW

ánde=ta =tsû aʔí=ndekhû kánse-ʔchu túyaʔkaen kukuyá=ndekhû kánse-ʔchu

land=NEW =3 person=PL.H live-EN and demon=PL.H live-EN

"The earth is where human beings live, but also where the demons live."

(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 28; 2024-06-07(2)_mll)

b. CASE MARKED PHRASE + -*JA* CNTR; ADJECTIVE + -*YI* EXCL

tsé=ni=jan úshaʔchu ñú-tshi-a=yi =tsû

STA=LOC=CNTR everything good-PA-ADN=EXCL =3

"There's nothing but good things there." (2 Peter 3:13; 2026-04-23(1)_mll)

10 A'ingae word order is largely free in matrix clauses, but predominantly verb-final in subordinate clauses. Consequently, I talk about the IS morphemes variably as attaching to clauses, predicates, or verbs/noun phrases/adjectives without any intended difference in meaning.

c. ADVERB + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
tayúpi-ta =tsû Erisión tsáiʔmbiʔtshi teteté=ndekhû=ve fíthi~ʔthi
long ago-NEW =3 Erisión many Waorani=PL.H=ACC2 kill~PLA
"Once upon a time, Erisión killed many Waoranis."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 152; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

d. BARE NOUN + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD
máki máma=ʔkhe yáya=iʔkhû nasípa=ni já
some day mom=ADD dad=INS field=LOC go
"Some days, mom also goes with dad into the field."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 17; `2024-06-10(1)_mll`)

For all the different base-of-attachment categories seen above, the new topic *-ta* NEW (22a, 22c), contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR (22b), and exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL (22b) are realized as plain (i. e. not preglottalized). The additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD is always preglottalized (22d).

In the rest of this section, I present the patterns of -CV/-ʔCV alternation when the IS markers attach to various verbs/predicates, including infinitive clauses (§5.2), finite clauses (with verbal and non-verbal predicates) (§5.3), and nominalized as well as adverbialized clauses (§5.4). These constitute the key data that will be accounted for in Section 6.

5.2 *Infinitive predicates*

A'ingae infinitives have several different functions, some of which overlap with English. Infinitive verbs can, for example, introduce rationale clauses (23a), function as subjects of stative predicates (23b), or be selected by verbs such as the habitual auxiliary *atesû* 'know' (23c) or the control verb *seʔpi* prohibit (23d).

(23) PREGLOTTALIZED REALIZATION ON INFINITIVES WITH *-YE* INF (also see Section A.2)

a. *YE*-RATIONALE + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
júsû afa-khú-ye-ʔ-yi-ta =ngi áʔingae=ma atésû-ʔje
only speak-RCPR-INF-T-EXCL-NEW =1 A'ingae=ACC learn-IPFV
"I am studying A'ingae only so that I can argue (with people)."
(`2025-01-20(1)_mll`)

b. *YE*-SUBJECT + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
atesû-ye-ʔ-ja biá-ʔ-a =tsû
learn-INF-T-CNTR long-PA2-ADN =3
"Gaining knowledge (of ayahuasca) is (a) long (process)."
(Criollo and Blanco Pisabarro, 1992, p. 53; `2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

c. *YE*-ARGUMENT + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
kítsa =tsû khû́mba=ma afé-si tsá=ma shúnʔchhan-mba fíʔthi-ye-ʔ-ja atesû́-ʔya
father =3 tobacco=ACC give-DS ANA=ACC smoke-SS kill-INF-T-CNTR learn-ASSR
"(His) father gave (him) tobacco, and he learned to hunt by smoking it."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 112; `2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

d. *YE*-ARGUMENT + ADDITIVE FOCUS -ʔ*KHE* ADD
án-ñe-ʔkhe séʔpi =ngi
eat-INF-ADD forbid =1
"I also forbid eating." (`2024-06-11(2)_mll`)

All of these uses are compatible with IS markers. When appearing on an infinitive verb, regardless of its function,[11] the discourse marker is always preceded by the glottal stop *-ʔ* (23). The additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD is always realized as preglottalized (23d). If multiple IS markers appear on a predicate (such as an infinitive), a glottal stop is observed only before the first one (23a). This fact supports the view that *-ʔ* is a separate morpheme, and not a part of the discourse markers' allomorphs.

5.3 *Finite predicates*

Now, I will look at finite predicates with IS morphemes. A'ingae finite clauses may be (co)subordinated with morphemes including the same-subject marker *-pa* SS (24a), different-subject marker *-si* DS (24b), apprehensional *-saʔne* APPR (24c) tentative *-khen* TENT (24d), and different-subject conditional marker *-ʔni* IF.DS (24e).[12] (Same-subject conditional antecedent marking, which is somewhat more complex, is discussed separately.) For a description of A'ingae subordinate clause meanings and uses, see Dąbkowski (2025c, 2026a).

(24) PLAIN REALIZATION ON FINITE (CO)SUBORDINATE CLAUSES (also see Section A.2)

a. *PA*-PREDICATE + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
amphí-pa-ta =ti=ki tsífu=ja báthi-ʔchu-mbi?
fall-SS-NEW =YNQ=2 neck=CNTR dislocate-EN-NEG
"Didn't you injure your neck by falling?"
(Borman, Cooper, and Criollo, 1991, p. 60; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

b. *SI*-PREDICATE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL
tsá=ma áthe-pa kúse índi-ye rúnʔda-ʔma áthe-mbi tíse ána-si-yi
ANA=ACC see-SS night catch-INF wait-FRST see-NEG 3SG sleep-DS-EXCL
jí-pa já-ʔje-si
come-SS go-IPFV-DS

11 Following standard assumptions (e. g. Adger, 2003), some of the uses of infinitive clauses may be analyzed as TPs, while others as CPs. Since their specific syntactic category will turn out immaterial in Section 6, I abstract away from this distinction here.

12 A'ingae clauses can also be subordinated with the frustrative *-ʔma* FRST. Since frustrative clauses are incompatible with discourse marking, I do not discuss them here.

"Having seen her, (he) waited to catch (her) at night, but (he) didn't see (her), because (she) would only come and go when he was asleep."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 156; `2024-06-18(1)_mll`)

c. *saʔne*-avertive precautioning + contrastive topic *-ja* cntr
tayúpi=ja jungáesû=ma séma-ʔjen-ʔ-jan tsé-ʔthi=nga =tsû máʔkaen
long ago=cntr something=acc work-ipfv-T-cntr sta-plc=dat =3 somehow
jungáesû=ma kháʔna-saʔne-jan íyûʔû-pa kúndase-ʔfa
something=acc steal-appr-cntr scold-ss tell-pls
"In the old days, when (young people) were working on something (for someone else), (their fathers) would caution them not to steal anything from there."
(Criollo and Blanco Pisabarro, 1992, pp. 43, 90; `2024-03-04(1)_sia`)

d. *khen*-predicate + contrastive topic *-ja* cntr
tsá=ma=nda =tsû Tûrû́rû dûshû́=ndekhû, tise dûʔshû dûshû́=ndekhû
ana=acc=new =3 Tururu child=pl.h 3sg child child=pl.h
thûthû́-khen-jan iyikhú-ʔfa-ʔchu
fell-tent-cntr fight-pls-en
"This (tree), the children of Tururu and the children of the children of Tururu struggled to cut down."
(Criollo and Blanco Pisabarro, 1992, p. 15; `2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

e. *ʔni*-antecedent + new topic *-ta* new
thési=ʔu ji-ñá-ʔni-nda míngae =ki khûshá-ya?
jaguar=aug come-prsp-if.ds-new how =2 survive-irr
"If the jaguar is coming, how are you going to save yourself?"
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 117; `2026-04-23(1)_mll`)

The five different types of subordinate clauses seen above are all compatible with discourse marking. When appearing on any of the subordinate clauses (24), the discourse markers are realized as plain (i. e. not preglottalized).

Same-subject conditional antecedents differ from other subordinate clauses in that they do not, in most circumstances, receive any overt dedicated marking. Rather, they are distinguished by carrying only an IS marker. When marking a same-subject (SS) conditional antecedent, the discourse morpheme always appears with preceding preglottalization (25). If more than one discourse marker appears on an SS antecedent, preglottalization appears only before the first one (25c) (except for the additive focus *-ʔkhe* add (25d), which is always preglottalized). In most other constructions, discourse morphology is optional. However, an SS antecedent is always marked by at least one IS morpheme.

(25) PREGLOTTALIZED REALIZATION ON SAME-SUBJECT CONDITIONALS (also see Section A.2)

a. UNMARKED ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + NEW TOPIC -TA NEW
ña yáya=ʔ=ta =tsû afé-ya fae regálo=ve ña=nga
1SG dad=T=NEW =3 give-IRR one gift=ACC2 1SG=DAT
"If (he)'s my dad, he'll give me a gift." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

b. UNMARKED ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -JA CNTR
afa-khú-ʔ-ja sumbú-ya =ngi
speak-RCPR-T-CNTR leave-IRR =1
"If I argue, I will leave." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

c. UNMARKED ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -YI EXCL + NEW TOPIC -TA NEW
tsá-ʔka-en kánse-ʔfa-ʔ-yi-ta =ki ñuáʔme shaká-ʔfa-ya-mbi
ANA-SA-ADV live-PLS-T-EXCL-NEW =2 truly lack-PLS-IRR-NEG
"Only if you live like this, you will truly not lack (anything)."
(Thessalonians 4:12; 2024-06-07(1)_mll)

d. UNMARKED ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -YI EXCL + -ʔKHE ADD
vá ni fae ávû=mbi=ʔ=yi=ʔkhe =tsû ami-án-ña-mbi
DEM neither one fish=NEG=T=EXCL=ADD =3 fill up-CAUS-IRR-NEG
"If this is not even a single fish, it won't fill me up." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

A different structure is seen when the additive focus marker *-ʔkhe* ADD is the only morpheme marking a same-subject conditional antecedent. In those cases, an additional morpheme *-ʔa* IF.SS is obligatorily present between the subordinated verb and *-ʔkhe* ADD (26).

(26) SAME-SUBJECT CONDITIONAL MARKED WITH -ʔA IF.SS WHEN FOLLOWED BY -ʔKHE ADD

a. ʔA-ANTECEDENT + ADDITIVE FOCUS -ʔKHE ADD
khúpa-ʔnga-pa jí-ʔa-ʔkhe =tsû utishí-ya-ʔchu
defecate-AND-SS come-IF.SS-ADD =3 wash hands-IRR-EN
"After using the restroom, one must also wash hands."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 27; 2024-06-07(1)_mll)

b. ʔA-ANTECEDENT + ADDITIVE FOCUS -ʔKHE ADD
kuénza áʔi=ve dá-ʔa-ʔkhe ñú-ʔ-a áʔi=ya =tsû
old person=ACC2 become-IF.SS-ADD good-PA2-ADN person=IRR =3
"Also when s/he grows old, s/he will be a good person."
(Borman, 1981, pp. 16–17; 2025-01-20(1)_mll)

The morpheme *-ʔa* does not (often) appear in circumstances other than before *-ʔkhe* ADD in same-subject conditional clauses. In addition, it is disallowed before the other IS markers (27). (Its use with the other IS markers is ungrammatical regardless of whether or not they are preceded by -ʔ T.) Consequently, in Section 6, I will analyze *-ʔa* as an allomorph of the (otherwise ∅) feature bundle [IF, SS] selected specifically when adjacent to *-ʔkhe* ADD.

(27) Overt -*ʔa* if.ss allowed and required only immediately before -*ʔkhe* add

a. **jí-ʔa(-ʔ)-ta*	b. **jí-ʔa(-ʔ)-ja*	c. **jí-ʔa(-ʔ)-yi*	d. **jí-ʔkhe*
come-if.ss-T-new	come-if.ss-T-cntr	come-if.ss-T-excl	come-add
intended: "if (sb) comes"	intended: "if (sb) comes"	intended: "only if (sb) comes"	intended: "also if (sb) comes"

(2025-01-20(1)_mll)

Recall that the IS morphemes may also appear on non-predicates, in which case they are not preceded by a glottal stop. This gives rise to minimal pairs, where non-verbal predicates (28b) may be distinguished from arguments (28a) solely by the presence of -*ʔ* T.

(28) Minimal (*ʔ*)*ta*-pair on a noun (also see Section A.2)

a. argument + new topic -*ta* new
tíse chán=da =tsû jí-ya-mbi
3sg mother=new =3 come-irr-neg
"His/her mother will not come." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

b. predicate + -*ʔ* T + new topic -*ta* new
tíse chán=ʔ=da =tsû jí-ya-mbi
3sg mother=T=new =3 come-irr-neg
"If she is a mother, she won't come." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

5.4 *Nominalized and adverbialized predicates*

Finally, I consider cases where information structural markers attach to nominalized and adverbialized clauses. First, A'ingae has a large set of nominalizing suffixes (Fischer and Hengeveld, 2023; Dąbkowski, 2025b, 2026b), including, among others, the event nominalizer -*ʔchu* en (29a) and the negative nominalizer -*mbi* nn (29b). When a discourse marker appears on a nominalized verb or clause, it is not preceded by a glottal stop (29).

(29) Plain realization on nominalizations (also see Section A.2)

a. *ʔchu*-nominalization + new topic -*ta* new
aʔí=ndekhû áfa-ʔje-ʔchu-ta =tsû khuánifae-ʔkhu chíga: Chíga, Kúse=ʔsû Chíga, Kuéje Chíga
person=pl.h speak-ipfv-en-new =3 three-qnt god: god night=attr god sun god
"The Cofán speak of three gods: God, the Moon, and the Sun."
(Criollo and Blanco Pisabarro, 1992, p. 17; 2026-04-23(1)_mll)

b. *mbi*-nominalization + contrastive topic -*ja* cntr
tsún-si tsa panzá-mbi-ja tise ûfákhuʔkhu=ma isû́-pa já áʔchu=ma ûfá-ye
do-ds ana hunt-nn-cntr 3sg blowgun=acc take-ss go monkey=acc blow-inf
"Then the bad hunter took his blowgun and went to kill the monkey."
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 120; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

When a nominalized clause functions as a predicate in a same-subject conditional antecedent, however, the discourse marker is preceded by a glottal stop *-ʔ* (30b). Such constructions may, again, contrast minimally with similar sentences where the nominalized clause is an argument and the glottal stop is not observed (30a).

(30) MINIMAL *ʔCHU*(*ʔ*)*TA*-PAIR

a. NOMINALIZED *ʔCHU*-ARGUMENT + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
pá-ʔchu-ta =tsû jí-ya-mbi
die-EN-NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG
"(The) dead (one) will not come." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

b. NOMINALIZED *ʔCHU*-PREDICATE + *-ʔ* T + TOPIC *-TA* NEW
pá-ʔchu-ʔ-ta =tsû jí-ya-mbi
die-EN-T-NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG
"If s/he's dead, s/he will not come." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

As for A'ingae adverbialized clauses, two types can be distinguished: adverbialized nominalizations and negative adverbials. Adverbialized nominalizations involve a clausal nominalization, often formed with the event nominalizer *-ʔchu* EN, followed by the adverbializing *-e* ADV. Adverbialized nominalizations can, among other things, function as arguments of *da* 'become' (31a) or rationale clauses (31b). When appearing on adverbialized nominalizations, the discourse markers surfaced without preglottalization (31).

(31) PLAIN ON ADVERBIALIZED NOMINALIZATIONS WITH *-ʔCHU-E* EN-ADV(also see Section A.2)

a. *ʔCHUE*-ARGUMENT + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
panzá-ya-ʔchu-e-ta =ngi dá
hunt-IRR-EN-ADV-NEW =1 become
"I was chosen to hunt." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

b. DIFFERENT-SUBJECT *ʔCHUE*-RATIONALE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
séma-ʔjen =ngi (kû́intsû) tíse ánkheʔsû=ma áʔmbian-ña-ʔchu-e-yi
work-IPFV =1 PURP.DS 3SG food=ACC have-IRR-EN-ADV-EXCL
"I'm working so that s/he (can) have food." (2025-08-21(1)_mll)

In addition to the adverbialized nominalizations, A'ingae also has negative adverbial clauses marked with *-mbe* ADV.NEG. The negative adverbials can function as arguments of verbs such as the auxiliary verb *kan* AUX (32a) or as adjuncts introducing "negative circumstance" clauses (32b). When an IS marker attaches to a negative adverbial clause, a glottal stop *-ʔ* precedes it (32).

(32) PREGLOTTALIZED ON NEGATIVE ADVERBIALS WITH *-MBE* ADV.NEG (also see Section A.2)

a. *MBE*-ARGUMENT + -ʔ T + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
máʔkaen tsún-mba =ngi úshaʔchu pû́iyiʔkhu=nga setsá-kheʔsû pákheʔsû=ma
how do-SS =1 everything everyone=DAT infect-HN disease=ACC
setsa-yé-mbe-ʔ-ta kán-ña?
infect-PASS-ADV.NEG-T-NEW AUX-IRR
"What can I do to avoid contracting contagious diseases?"
(Pederson and Cooper, 1982, p. 41; `2025-07-17(1)_mll`)

b. NEGATIVE CIRCUMSTANCE *MBE*-ADJUNCT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
áthe-pa fíʔthi-mbe-ʔ-yi jí táyu kúse-ji-si
see-SS kill-ADV.NEG-T-EXCL come already night-INGR-DS
"I saw (the toucan but) I came (back home) without killing (it) because it was already getting dark."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982a, p. 40; `2025-07-22(1)_mll`)

Elsewhere, A'ingae negation is expressed with *-mbi* NEG, and adverbialization is achieved with *-e* ADV. Yet, the negative adverbial in the examples above is glossed as one morpheme (*-mbe* ADV.NEG), not as an adverbialization of a negative clause (**-mb-e* NEG-ADV). This is because the negative *-mbi* NEG is compatible with the templatically preceding situation-level suffixes *-ʔfa* PLS (33a) and *-ya* IRR (33b), but the negative adverbial *-mbe* ADV.NEG is not compatible with either (Hengeveld and Fischer, in prep.) (34) (also see Section 6.2). Morphotactic differences like this are unsurprising if *-mbe* ADV.NEG is a separate morpheme but would be unexplained if *-mbe* were a reduction of **-mb-e* NEG-ADV.[13]

(33) NEGATIVE *-MBI* NEG COMPATIBLE WITH *-ʔFA* PLS, *-YA* IRR

a. *así-ʔfa-mbi*
fish-PLS-NEG
"(they) did not fish"
(`2025-11-06(1)_jxm`)

b. *así-ya-mbi*
fish-IRR-NEG
"will not fish"
(`2025-11-06(1)_jxm`)

(34) NEGATIVE ADVERBIAL *-MBE* ADV.NEG INCOMPATIBLE WITH *-ʔFA* PLS, *-YA* IRR

a. **así-ʔfa-mbe*
fish-PLS-ADV.NEG
intended: "without (them) fishing"
(`2025-08-12(1)_jxm`)

b. **así-ya-mbe*
fish-IRR-ADV.NEG
intended: "without being about to fish"
(`2025-08-12(1)_jxm`)

In summary, in most contexts, the IS markers are not preceded by a glottal stop. The glottal stop appears only when a discourse marker attaches to an infinitival clause, a same-

13 Additionally, a reduction of */*-mbi-e*/ to [*-mbe*] would be unexpected on phonological grounds. In A'ingae, the sequence [*ie*] forms a (rare but) licit diphthong. Notably, the sequence *-mbi-e* is actually attested when the adverbializing suffix *-e* ADV appears on *mbi*-final non-verbal constituents, such *tsaiʔmbi* 'many' (iia) and *khupa-mbi* 'defecate-NN' "constipated" (iib). There are no independent reasons to believe that *-e* ADV should have a different phonological behavior on *mbi*-negated verbs than it does on *tsaiʔmbi* 'many' or *khupa-mbi* 'defecate-NN.'

subject conditional antecedent (which lacks an overt subordinator), or a negative adverbial *mbe*-clause. These environments are repeated in (35).

(35) SUMMARY OF ENVIRONMENTS FOR IS MARKER PREGLOTTALIZATION
The IS markers are preglottalized only when attaching to:
  a. *infinitival clauses with -ye* INF*,*
  b. *finite subordinate clauses which do not have an overt subordinator (i. e. same-subject conditional antecedents), and*
  c. *negative adverbial clauses with -mbe* ADV.NEG*.*

Otherwise, the IS markers are not preceded by a glottal stop.

6 ANALYSIS

In this section, I provide an analysis of the A'ingae IS-preglottalization pattern. In Section 6.1, I briefly discuss Mikkelsen's (2015) and Bossi and Diercks's (2019) accounts of information structure differentiation in in Kipsigis and Danish. In Section 6.2, I adopt their discourse feature geometry to capture the A'ingae data and present an analysis couched in Distributed Morphology (DM) (e. g. Halle and Marantz, 1993, 1994; Embick and Noyer, 2007). In Section 6.3, I present an application of the proposal to the A'ingae patterns.

6.1 *Discourse feature geometry*

In Danish (North Germanic, Denmark), in some contexts, the clause-initial position may be filled by different phrases, including e. g. discourse categories such as topic and focus, expressions related to illocutionary force (such as WH-words), and constituents that establish a rhetorical relation to the preceding sentence (such as adverbs) (Mikkelsen, 2015, p. 21), but not expletives or discourse-old subjects (Mikkelsen, 2015, p. 12). For example, in the continuation of (36), the fronted constituent can be the VP anaphor *det* VPA (36a) or a rhetorical adverb such as *heldigvis* 'luckily' (36b). However, the expletive *der* 'there' cannot be fronted (36c). In the examples below, the fronted constituents are underlined.

(ii) HETEROMORPHEMIC [*I-E*] LICIT IN ADVERBIALIZATION
  a. LICIT [*I-E*] IN *TSAIʔMBI-E* 'MANY-ADV'
     tsáiʔmbi-e bu-ñá-mba khá-ne-ñi fíthi~ʔthi-ye ánshaen tetéte=ve=yi
     many-ADV meet-CAUS-SS else-ELAT-EXCL kill~PLA-INF begin Waorani=ACC2=EXCL
     "When he had piled up many of them, he began to kill the Waoranis from afar."
     (Borman and Criollo, 1990, p. 173; `2025-07-22(1)_mll`)
  b. LICIT [*I-E*] IN *KHUPA-MBI-E* 'DEFECATE-NN-ADV'
     khupá-mbi-e =ti=ki dáʔ
     defecate-NN-ADV =YNQ=2 become
     "Are you constipated?" (Borman, Cooper, and Criollo, 1991, p. 37; `2025-08-12(1)_jxm`)

(36) FRONTING OF IS-DIFFERENTIATED CONSTITUENT IN DANISH (Mikkelsen, 2015, p. 19)
da jeg åbnede døren troede jeg først at der havde [været indbrud]$_{VP}$, men ...
when 1SG opened door.DEF thought 1SG first that there had been break in but
"When I opened the door, I first thought that someone had broken into the house but ... "

a. LICIT FRONTING OF THE VP ANAPHOR *DET* VPA
det havde der heldigvis ikke
VPA had there luckily not

b. LICIT FRONTING OF A RHETORICAL ADVERB
heldigvis havde der ikke det
luckily had there not VPA

c. ILLICIT FRONTING OF A DISCOURSE-UNDISTINGUISHED EXPLETIVE
**der havde (det) heldigvis ikke (det)*
there had VPA luckily not VPA
"luckily there hadn't (been a break-in)."

To capture the above data, Mikkelsen (2015) proposes that "[in] Danish, Spec,CP must be occupied by an information-structurally distinguished element, but is not dedicated to a particular function" (p. 634). In other words, the notion relevant for capturing which constituents can surface in the clause-initial position is that of general underspecified *information structural differentiation*, which can be satisfied in a variety of ways (e. g. by the aforementioned information-structural, illocutionary, or rhetorical properties).

Bossi and Diercks (2019) observe that an empirically similar pattern is present in Kipsigis (Nilo-Saharan, Kenya), where fronting is mandatory for a discourse-prominent item (where is "discourse-prominent" is likewise understood as having one of many discourse functions).[14] To account for the discourse-driven word order of Kipsigis, Bossi and Diercks (2019) build on Mikkelsen's (2015) insight and formalize *information structural differentiation* as "an underspecified [δ] (discourse) feature that can be satisfied by phrases of any information structure designation or—even more generally—by any phrase that is sufficiently discourse-differentiated" (p. 30).[15] (Concretely, the Kipsigis fronting is modeled as movement to Spec,TP triggered by an uninterpretable [δ] borne by T°; p. 30.)

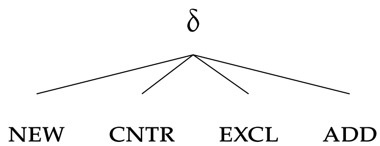
6.2 *Distributed Morphology formalization*

In my analysis of the A'ingae patterns, I adopt Bossi and Diercks's (2019) feature geometry directly and propose that the four IS morphemes (*-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, *-yi* EXCL, *-ʔkhe* ADD) are the exponents of four discourse features: [NEW], [CNTR], [EXCL], and [ADD]. The IS features are organized hierarchically, with a superordinate *discourse* feature [δ] dominating the

14 However, in Kipsigis, the landing site for the fronted constituent is the immediately postverbal position.
15 Additionally, a similar claim is made by Kim (2015) for the Korean marker -(*n*)*un*. While -(*n*)*un* is traditionally analyzed as a contrastive topic, Kim (2015) proposes that -(*n*)*un* only serves to "impose salience on a discourse referent" and that "[t]opicality and contrast [are] ... derived from the interaction of the proposed meaning of -(*n*)*un* and various syntactic, semantic, and pragmatic factors" (p. 87).

four more specific features. A tree representing a minimally differentiated organization of the relevant IS features is repeated in (37).[16] As in all feature-geometric systems (e. g. Harley and Ritter, 2002; Abels, 2012; Boas and Sag, 2012; Aravind, 2018), I assume that the presence of a lower feature entails the presence of the hierarchically higher one.

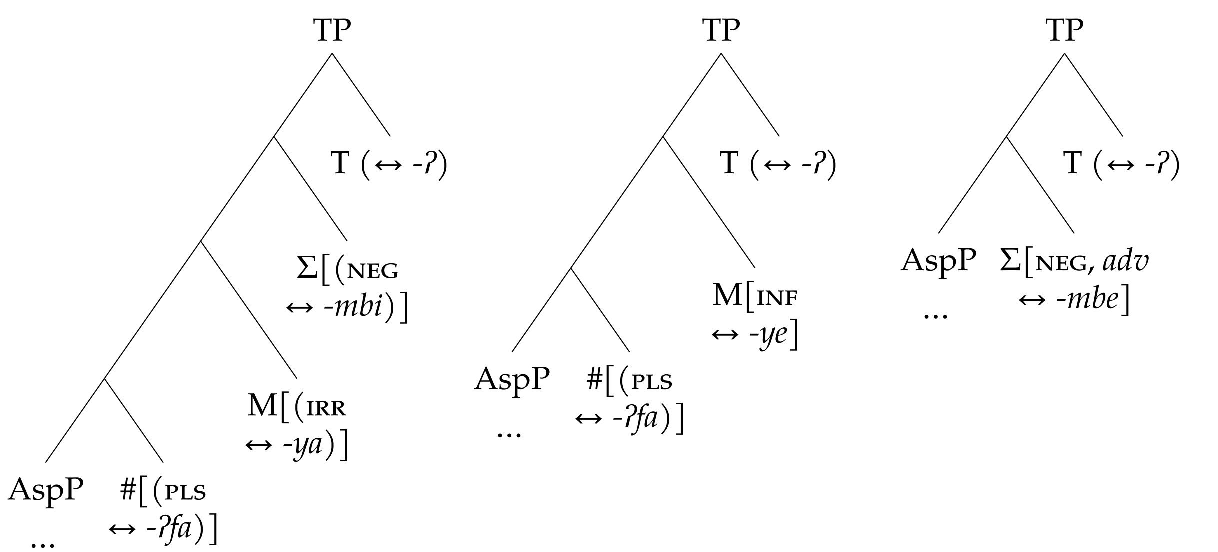
(37) Discourse feature geometry



I propose that the discourse feature [δ] is the context in which T° is realized as a glottal stop *-ʔ*. I assume a decompositional approach to T, where overt situation-level suffixes are realized as heads below T° (38).

Specifically, I assume that every clause—by definition—contains the TP layer (Shlonsky, 1997, p. 3). Additionally, I assume that TP dominates the projections which realize negation (Pollock, 1989; Laka Mugarza, 1990) and irrealis mood (Cinque, 1999), and that the hierarchical order of the number (#P), mood (MP), and polarity (ΣP) projections mirrors the linear order of suffixes they introduce (*-ʔfa* PLS, *-ya* IRR, and *-mbi* NEG). Taken together, the above premises zero in on the finite TP structure given in (38a).

(38) TP structure
a. finite TPs b. infinitive TPs c. negative adverbial TPs



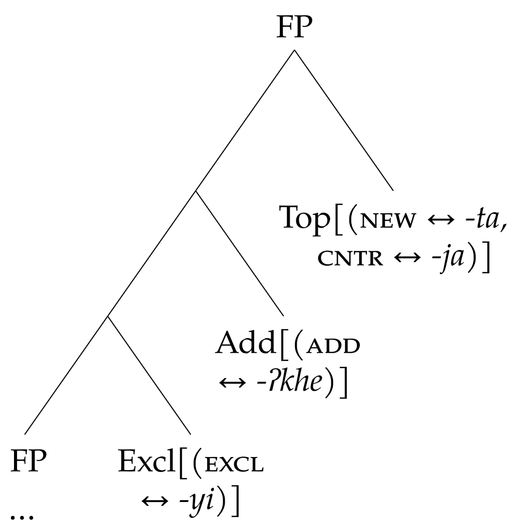
16 Although the figure in (37) shows minimally differentiated discourse feature organization, the proposal is compatible with more hierarchical systems. For example, following Krifka (2008), one may take contrastive topic [CNTR] to inherit from higher-order topic [TOP] and focus [FOC] features.

The A'ingae infinitive *ye*-clauses can be marked for subject plurality (*-ʔfa* PLS), but not for reality (**-ya* IRR) or negation (**-mbi* NEG). Following Wurmbrand (1998), I assume that TP dominates the projection that realizes finiteness. The infinitive TP structure is given in (38b).

The negative adverbial *mbe*-clauses cannot be marked for subject plurality (**-ʔfa* PLS) or reality (**-ya* IRR). Since the negative adverbial marker *-mbe* ADV.NEG is a single morpheme (32), I assume that it is a realization of one syntactic head that hosts both the negative [NEG] and adverbial categorizing [*adv*] features. The structure of the negative adverbial TPs is given in (38c).

The A'ingae discourse markers can co-occur. The exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL can be followed by the additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD, and the focus markers can be followed by a topic marker (either *-ta* NEW or *-ja* CNTR). This means that the A'ingae IS morphemes are introduced across at least three separate functional projections (39), corresponding to slots (xii-xiv) in Table 2. The IS markers are adjuncts. This means that the label they project (here, FP) is the same as the label of the projection to which they attach.

(39) STRUCTURE OF DISCOURSE MARKER PROJECTIONS



Note that all four discourse markers inherit from [δ]. However, they are introduced in different syntactic projections. As such, there is no direct correlation between [δ] and a specific syntactic projection.

As previously stated, I propose that the glottal stop *-ʔ* discussed throughout this paper is a contextual realization of T°. Concretely, T° is realized as a glottal stop *-ʔ* when linearly adjacent to the discourse feature [δ]. The critical vocabulary item (VI) is given in (40a). Since *-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, *-yi* EXCL, and *-ʔkhe* ADD all inherit from [δ], they all satisfy this environment condition. Otherwise, T° is realized as phonologically null (40b). This derives the observed distribution of the IS-conditioned *-ʔ*. All VIs relevant to the analysis are given in (40-42).

(40) FEATURES ≼ TP
a. T ⟷ -ʔ / _ δ
b. T ⟷ -∅ / elsw.
c. PLS ⟷ *-ʔfa*
d. IRR ⟷ *-ya*
e. INF ⟷ *-ye*
f. NEG, *adv* ⟷ *-mbe*
g. NEG ⟷ *-mbi*

(41) C-HEADS
a. IF, SS ⟷ *-ʔa* / _ ADD
b. IF, SS ⟷ -∅ / elsw.
c. SS ⟷ *-pa*
d. IF, DS ⟷ *-ʔni*[17]
e. DS ⟷ *-si*
f. APPR ⟷ *-saʔne*
g. TENT ⟷ *-khen*

(42) DISCOURSE FEATURES
a. NEW ⟷ *-ta*
b. CNTR ⟷ *-ja*
c. EXCL ⟷ *-yi*
d. ADD ⟷ *-ʔkhe*

6.3 *Application of the proposal*

Now, I will demonstrate how the proposed analysis accounts for the data. When an IS marker attaches to most syntactic categories, including DPs (43a) and adverbs (43b), there is no T° adjacent to a discourse-marked morpheme. As such, *-ʔ* is not realized. The constituent to which the IS markers are attached is bracketed [ ].

(43) MOST CATEGORIES: *-ʔ* NOT REALIZED
a. DP + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
[yáya]$_{\text{DP}}$*=ta =tsû tsámpi=ni já*
dad=NEW =3 forest=LOC go
"Dad went hunting." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)
b. ADVERB + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
[tayúpi]$_{advP}$*-ja fíthi~ʔthi =tsû*
long ago-CNTR kill~PLA =3
"Once upon a time, s/he killed (many)." (2024-10-08(1)_mll)

When a discourse marker attaches immediately to an infinitive TP (e. g. a complement of a raising predicate, such as the habitual auxiliary *atesû* 'know') (44a), the adjacent T-head is realized as *-ʔ* (40a). In the examples below, spans stretching from T° through the discourse markers are underlined. For some of the core cases, a tree structure of the IS-marked word is given below the example, e. g. (44b). The environment is connected to the feature whose allomorphic realization it determines with an arrow (⟶).

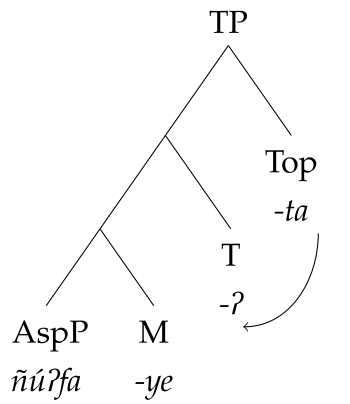
17 The different subject antecedent *-ʔni* IF.DS is preglottalized and attaches to a TP. As such, one may ask if the preglottalization should be reanalyzed as the *ʔ*-allomorph of T°, and the different subject conditional marker as underlyingly plain (i. e. [IF, DS] ⟷ *-ni*). However, since the different subject conditional antecedent feature bundle [IF, DS] does not contain a discourse feature (i. e. which would inherit from [δ]), the bundle [IF, DS] would not trigger the realization of T° as *-ʔ*. Consequently, this analysis cannot be adopted. Importantly however, positing that *-ʔni* IF.DS is underlyingly preglottalized does not weaken the analysis or incur an additional theoretical cost. A large set of A'ingae morphemes, including many verbal suffixes, e. g. *-ʔje* IPFV, *-ʔñakha* ITER, *-ʔfa* PLS, etc. (seen in Table 2), as well as many non-verbal ones, e. g. *=ʔye* DCS, *-ʔchu* RND, start with a /ʔ/ which cannot be attributed to the presence of T°. To put it plainly, certain A'ingae morphemes simply are underlyingly preglottalized, so it comes as no surprise that some of the C-heads are preglottalized, too.

(44) Raising predicate complement: -ʔ realized

a. -ʔ T + new topic -*ta* NEW

[ñúʔfa-ye-ʔ]$_{TP}$*-ta =ngi atésû*
rest-INF-T-NEW =1 know
"I (habitually) rest." (2024-10-08(1)_mll)

b. structure of *ñúʔfa-ye-ʔ-ta*



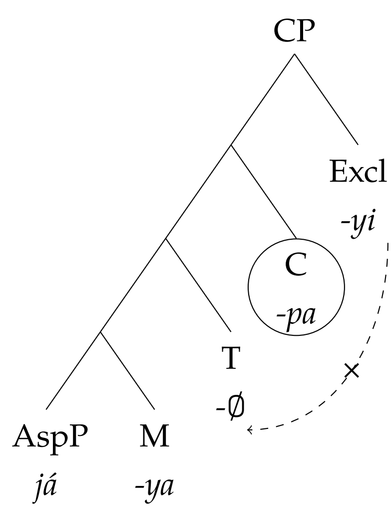
When an IS marker attaches to CP with an overt subordinating C°, there is overt material intervening between T° and the IS marker (45a). Since the environments conditioning allomorphy are strictly local (Embick, 2010, 2015), -ʔ is not realized (40b).[18] In (45b), the blocking of ʔ-allomorphy caused by overt intervening material (-*pa* SS) is represented with a dashed crossed-out arrow (-×->). The blocking suffix is circled.

(45) Overtly-subordinated clause: -ʔ not realized

a. null-T + overt C + exclusive focus -*yi* EXCL

[já-ya-∅-pa]$_{CP}$*-yi =ngi ína-ʔjen*
go-IRR-T-SS-EXCL =1 cry-IPFV
"I'm crying only because I will leave." (2024-10-08(1)_mll)

b. structure of *já-ya-∅-pa-yi*



However, when an IS marker attaches to a CP with a null C°, such as a complement of a control predicate, e. g. *seʔpi* 'forbid' (46a), there is no overt morphology intervening between T° and the IS marker. I assume that phonologically unrealized material is ignored for purposes of satisfying allomorphy environments (*pruning* in Embick, 2010, 2015). As such, T° is realized as *-ʔ*.[19]

(46) CONTROL PREDICATE COMPLEMENT: *-ʔ* REALIZED

a. *-ʔ* T + NULL-C + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR

[*kéʔi án-ʔfa-ye-ʔ-∅*]$_{CP}$*-ja* *séʔpi* *=ngi*

2PL eat-PL-INF-T-C-CNTR forbid =1

"I prohibit y'all from eating." (2024-10-08(1)_mll)

Next, I propose that same-subject conditional antecedents are likewise introduced by a head that is phonologically unrealized in most environments (41b). Since, again, null material is ignored for the purposes of allomorphy (Embick, 2010, 2015), T° is realized as *-ʔ* (47a). In (47b), the phonologically empty (and hence pruned) C-node is given in a dashed circle.

(47) SAME-SUBJECT CONDITIONAL ANTECEDENT: *-ʔ* REALIZED

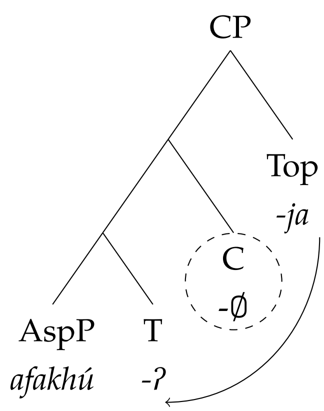
a. *-ʔ* T + NULL-C + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA CNTR*

[*afa-khú-ʔ-∅*]$_{CP}$*-ja* *sumbú-ya =ngi*

speak-RCPR-T-IF.SS-CNTR leave-IRR =1

"If I argue, I will leave." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

b. STRUCTURE OF *AFA-KHÚ-ʔ-∅-JA*



18 The assumption that infinitival morphology is TP-internal, while subordinating morphemes are C-heads, is widely accepted cross-linguistically (Adger, 2003), and corroborated for A'ingae in Dąbkowski (2022, 2024b).

19 Since silent heads are ignored for allomorph selection, the status of any clause as a TP or a silent-C° CP is immaterial for the analysis. Nevertheless, throughout the section, I represent phonologically null C-heads in contexts where they would be assumed by standard analyses of phenomena such as control, clausal adjunction, etc. (e. g. Adger, 2003).

This derives the fact that *-ʔ* T is realized on same-subject antecedents, but not on other types of subordinate clauses—only the same-subject antecedents are introduced by a phonologically unrealized feature bundle.[20]

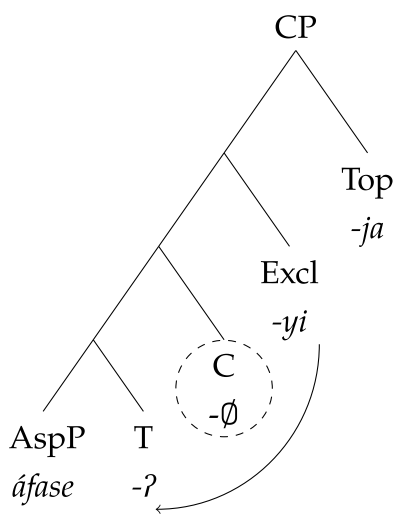
When several discourse markers are attached to a TP (or a CP headed by a phonologically null C°), the glottal stop *-ʔ* is realized only before the first one (48a). This is a direct consequence of the fact that *-ʔ* is a realization of T° (and there is normally only one T° per clause).

(48) MULTIPLE IS MARKERS: *-ʔ* REALIZED ONLY ONCE

a. *-ʔ* T + NULL-C + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI EXCL* + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW

[*thési=ma áfase-ʔ-∅*]$_{CP}$*-yi-ja* *bûthú-ya =ngi*
jaguar=ACC criticize-T-IF.SS-EXCL-CNTR run-IRR =1
"Only if I criticize a jaguar, I will run." (2024-06-06(2)_mll)

b. STRUCTURE OF *ÁFASE-ʔ-∅-YI-JA*



When a same-subject antecedent hosts the additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD, the morpheme *-ʔa* appears before it (49a). I propose that *-ʔa* is an allomorph of the same-subject conditional feature bundle introduced specifically in the context of *-ʔkhe* ADD (41a).[21]

20 Cross-linguistically, conditionals and topics are marked in similar, often identical, ways (Haiman, 1978). Under this analysis, A'ingae conditionality is encoded with dedicated morphosyntactic features (41a-b, 41d), different from the features responsible for discourse-related notions (42). Nevertheless, the IS markers are obligatorily on same-subject antecedents (47) and optional (though frequent) on different-subject antecedents (24e). The present analysis does not formally capture the fact that discourse marking on same-subject antecedents is obligatory. However, since the feature bundle expressing same-subject antecedent semantics is in most contexts phonologically unrealized, i. e. [IF, SS] ⟷ -∅ (41b), I speculate that the obligatory IS marking on same-subject antecedents may be functionally motivated: If there were no discourse markers, the same-subject antecedents would be morphologically indistinguishable from matrix clauses.

21 Since the morpheme *-ʔa* appears between a TP and the additive focus marker *-ʔkhe* ADD, one might wonder whether it should be analyzed as another allomorphic realization of T°, i. e. [T] ⟷ *-ʔa* / ADD _ δ. However, this alternative analysis predicts that *-ʔa* would also be selected for when the additive marker *-ʔkhe* ADD attaches to an infinitive. Since that is not the case (23d), I do not analyze *-ʔa* as an allomorph of T°.

(49) SAME-SUBJECT CONDITIONAL ANTECEDENT REALIZED AS -*ʔA* BEFORE -*ʔKHE* ADD

a. NULL-T + -*ʔA* IF.SS + ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔKHE* ADD

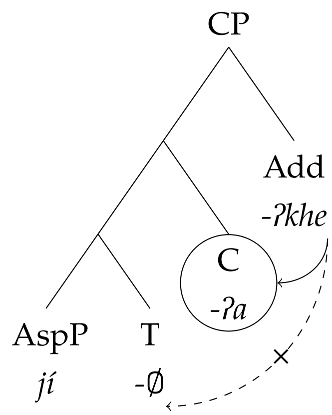
[khúpa-ʔnga-pa jí-∅-ʔa]$_{CP}$-ʔkhe =tsû utishí-ya-ʔchu

defecate-AND-SS come-T-IF.SS-ADD =3 wash hands-IRR-EN

"After using the restroom, one must also wash hands."

(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 27; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

b. STRUCTURE OF *JÍ-∅-ʔA-ʔKHE*



When an information structural marker attaches to a nominalized TP, there is a nominalizer, e. g. the bounded space classifier *-khû* BND (50a), intervening between T° and the marker. As such, T° is not realized as a glottal stop.

(50) NOMINALIZED CLAUSE: -*ʔ* NOT REALIZED

a. NULL-T + NOMINALIZER + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW

[án-ña-∅-khû]$_{DP}$-ta =tsû ránde

eat-IRR-T-BND-NEW =3 large

"The room where (s/he) will eat is large." (`2025-08-12(1)_jxm`)

When a nominalizer intervenes between the T-head and a discourse marker, T° is not realized as a glottal stop (51a). However, the nominalized clause can serve as a complement to another T° when it functions as a predicate (e. g. in a same-subject antecedent). The second T° is realized as a glottal stop -*ʔ* if linearly adjacent to a discourse marker (51b). Thus, the difference between (51a) and (51b) follows directly from their syntax.

(51) MINIMAL *ʔCHU*(*ʔ*)*TA*-PAIR

a. DP + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW

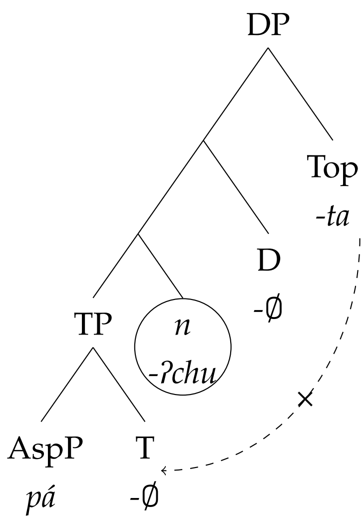
[pá-∅-ʔchu]$_{DP}$-ta =tsû jí-ya-mbi

die-T-EN-NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG

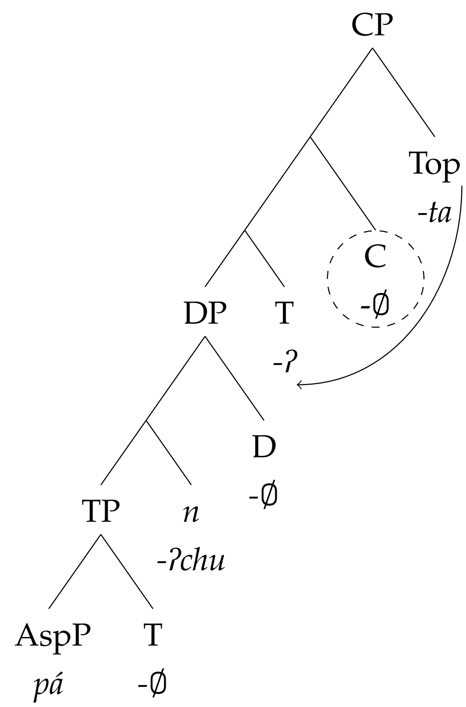
"(The) dead (one) will not come." (`2024-06-20(2)_mll`)

b. DP + *-ʔ* T + NULL-C + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
   [*pá-∅-ʔchu-ʔ-∅*]$_{CP}$*-ta* =*tsû jí-ya-mbi*
   die-T-EN-T-IF.SS-NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG
   "If s/he's dead, s/he will not come." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

c. STRUCTURE OF *PÁ-∅-ʔCHU-TA*



d. STRUCTURE OF *PÁ-∅-ʔCHU-ʔ-∅-TA*



When a discourse marker attaches to an adverbialized nominalization, there are two morphemes intervening between the T-head and the discourse marker (52a). As such, a glottal stop is not realized.

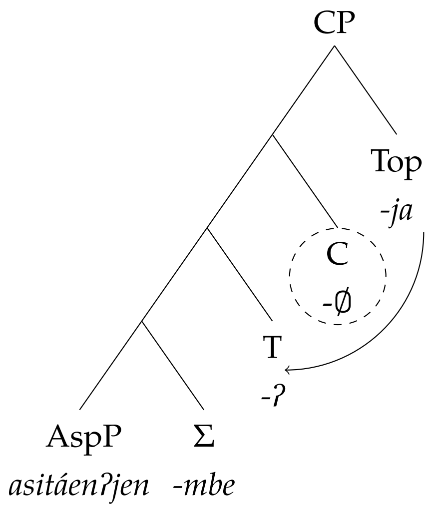
(52) ADVERBIALIZED NOMINALIZATION: *-ʔ* NOT REALIZED
   a. NULL-T + *-ʔCHU* EN + *-E* ADV + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
   [*panzá-ya-∅-ʔchu-e*]$_{advP}$*-ta* =*ngi dá*
   hunt-IRR-T-EN-ADV-NEW =1 become
   "I was chosen to hunt." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

I assume that the negative adverbial *-mbe* ADV.NEG is a single exponent which is introduced in the polarity projection (ΣP) and expresses both the negative [NEG] and adverbial categorizing [*adv*] features. Since ΣP is below TP, when a discourse marker attaches to a negative adverbial clause, no overt material intervenes between the T-head and the discourse marker. As such, T° is realized as a glottal stop *-ʔ* (53a).

(53) NEGATIVE ADVERBIAL: -*ʔ* REALIZED

a. -*MBE* ADV.NEG + -*ʔ* T + NULL-C + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
kánse =tsû [asitháen-ʔjen-mbe-ʔ-∅]$_{CP}$-ja
live =3 worry-IPFV-ADV.NEG-T-C-CNTR
"S/he lives without a care in the world." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

b. STRUCTURE OF *ASITHÁEN-ʔJEN-MBE-ʔ-∅-JA*



Finally, I propose that -*ʔkhe* ADD is underlyingly preglottalized (42d). I assume that -*ʔkhe* ADD participates in the same triggering of T-allomorphy as the other IS morphemes (54a), but two contiguous glottal stops are later phonologically reduced to one.

(54) ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔKHE* ADD: UNDERLYINGLY PREGLOTTALIZED

a. -*ʔ* T + NULL-C + ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔKHE* ADD
[án-ñe-ʔ-∅]$_{CP}$-ʔkhe séʔpi =ngi
eat-INF-T-C-ADD forbid =1
"I also forbid eating." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

In summary, we have seen that the glottal stop -*ʔ* appears at the right edge of TP when immediately followed by an IS morpheme. To capture this distribution, I have proposed that the glottal stop -*ʔ* is a realization of the T-head conditioned by linear adjacency to the discourse feature [δ]. The schema representing these structural conditions is repeated in (55).

(55) *ʔ*-REALIZATION SCHEMA

right edge of TP ↘
[*root* … ***-ʔ***]$_{TP}$ -*sfx*$_{[\delta]}$
↑ ↑ ↖ information structural morpheme
T° no overt material intervening

7 REJECTED ALTERNATIVES

I have proposed that the A'ingae glottal stop *-ʔ*, which is in certain environments realized as before discourse markers, is a contextual realization of T°. In this section, I consider a few alternative ways of thinking about *-ʔ* T, including a morphophonological analysis (§7.1), a spell-out boundary analysis (§7.2), an encliticization analysis (§7.3), a category feature analysis (§7.4), and an Ā-geometry analysis (§7.5). Ultimately, I conclude that all these alternative proposals should be rejected or dispreferred on empirical and/or theoretical grounds.

7.1 *Morphophonological analysis*

A'ingae phonology is characterized by a complex system of interactions between stress and glottalization. For example, in the *inner* morphological domain (which encompasses the root, VceP, and AspP), a glottal stop assigns stress to the syllable which contains the second mora to its left. E. g., when suffixed with the preglottalized *-ʔje* IPFV, the initial stresses of *áfase* 'offend' and *áfasi-an* 'offend-CAUS' shift to, respectively, *afáse-ʔje* 'offend-IPFV' and *afasi-án-ʔjen* 'offend-CAUS-IPFV' (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025c).

As such, one might ask whether the glottalization *-ʔ* analyzed here a spell-out of T° is in fact a morphophonological effect unrelated to the morphosyntactic properties of its base of attachment. Crucially, however, the potentially relevant morphophonological interactions are limited to glottal stops introduced in VceP and Asp. Those introduced in later projections (such as the TP and CP relevant here) are not conditioned by phonological factors and have no effect on the phonology of their bases. For example, when suffixed with TP/CP morphemes, the word-initial stress of *áfase* 'offend' remains unchanged, regardless of whether the high-attaching affix is plain, such as *-ya* IRR (*áfase-ya* 'offend-IRR'), or preglottalized, such as *-ʔfa* PLS (*áfase-ʔfa* 'offend-PLS').

Correspondingly, the glottal stop under investigation *-ʔ* T may surface, for example, on the stressed syllable (25b), or the second (23b), or third (23c) syllable after the stressed one. Likewise, *-ʔ* T may surface on bases which are plain (32a) or glottalized (25c). In any of these cases, *-ʔ* T is unaffected, and the preceding glottal stops and metrical structure are preserved. This shows that the realization of *-ʔ* T is not conditioned by any of the language's morphophonological effects. (For extensive discussions and analyses of A'ingae morphophonology, see Dąbkowski, 2021c, 2023a, 2024b, 2025c,e, 2026b.)

7.2 *Spell-out boundary analysis*

Alternatively, one might ask if the glottal stop *-ʔ* T is a phonological realization of a syntactic spell-out boundary. This alternative proposal may seem particularly salient, as many of the morphemes which appear at major morphosyntactic boundaries are preglottalized (56).

(56) PREGLOTTALIZATION AT MORPHOSYNTACTIC BOUNDARIES

[[[[*kufi -án* $]_{\text{VceP}}$ *-ʔjen -ngi* $]_{\text{AspP}}$ *-ʔfa -mbi* $]_{\text{TP}}$ *-ʔni -nda* $]_{\text{CP}}$

play -CAUS -IPFV -VEN -PLS -NEG -IF.DS -NEW

"now$_{\text{NEW}}$, if$_{\text{IF}}$ (they$_{\text{PLS}}$) do not$_{\text{NEG}}$ come$_{\text{VEN}}$ to be$_{\text{IPFV}}$ making$_{\text{CAUS}}$ play, (someone else$_{\text{DS}}$) ..." (`2024-06-18(1)_mll`)

Note, however, that there are other morphemes which occupy the same morphosyntactic slots, but come without preglottalization (57). This means that—for most morphemes—preglottalization must be analyzed as part of their underlying form.

(57) NO PREGLOTTALIZATION AT MORPHOSYNTACTIC BOUNDARIES

[[[[[*kanjaen -ñe* $]_{\text{VceP}}$ *-jín* $]_{\text{AspP}}$ *-mbi* $]_{\text{TP}}$ *-si -ta* $]_{\text{CP}}$ *=ti =ki* $]_{\text{CP}}$

show -PASS -INGR -NEG -DS -NEW =YNQ =2

"because$_{\text{DS}}$ (it$_{\text{DS}}$) is not$_{\text{NEG}}$ be about$_{\text{INGR}}$ to be$_{\text{PASS}}$ shown, do$_{\text{YNQ}}$ you$_2$ ..." (`2026-04-29(1)_mll`)

Since the *-ʔ* T under discussion comes at the right edge of a TP (and Dąbkowski, 2022, 2024b, 2025c argues that A'ingae TPs are phasal), it could be seen as marking a major morphosyntactic boundary. Yet, crucially, *-ʔ* T is realized only if the TP's right edge is followed by a discourse marker. As such, an account of the distribution of *-ʔ* T cannot be formulated without a reference to [δ].

7.3 *Encliticization analysis*

One may also suggest an account where the core complex morphological verb is derived by head movement, but the IS markers are encliticized onto the complex head. Under this analysis, the glottal stop *-ʔ* T would be an indication of a distinct structural relationship.

An argument against this idea comes from a consideration of other clitics in the language. A'ingae has a set of sentence-level clitics, which often appear after the first syntactic constituent of the sentence—hence I refer to them as second-position (P2) clitics. Regardless of their base of attachment, the P2 clitics are not preglottalized (58). In the examples below, the relevant clitics are underlined.

(58) NO PREGLOTTALIZATION BEFORE P2 CLITICS (from Dąbkowski, 2025c, 2026a)

a. *áthe-ʔya* <u>*=ki*</u> *thési=ma*

see-ASSR =2 jaguar=ACC

"You saw a jaguar." (`2024-03-28(1)_sia`)

b. *kurága* <u>*=te*</u> *thési=ma áthe*

shaman =RPRT jaguar=ACC see

"A shaman saw a jaguar (I am told)." (`2024-03-28(1)_sia`)

A'ingae adjectives may precede or follow the noun they modify. A'ingae case markers, such as the accusative *=ma* ACC, always attach to the right edge of the noun phrase, surfacing either on the noun (59a) or the adjective (59b), depending on the noun phrase's internal word order. This freedom of host selection shows that A'ingae case markers are clitics. However, they are not preglottalized.

(59) No preglottalization before case clitics (from Dąbkowski, 2025c)

a. *áthe =tsû ránde píndu=ma*
see =3 large hawk=ACC
"S/he saw a large hawk."

b. *áthe =tsû píndu ránde=ma*
see =3 hawk large=ACC
"S/he saw a large hawk."

(`2024-04-24(1)_sia`)

In sum, the preglottalization realized in certain contexts before the discourse markers *-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, and *-yi* EXCL cannot be attributed to their status as clitics.

7.4 *Category feature analysis*

In Section 6, I have proposed that *-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, *-yi* EXCL, and *-ʔkhe* ADD all inherit from a superordinate discourse feature [δ] by virtue of being discourse morphemes. Alternatively, one could imagine dispensing with the feature hierarchy by positing the existence of [Δ] as a category feature that coexists with the more specific discourse features. (Here, I am using a capital "Δ" by analogy with other functional category features, like C, D, or P.) In this analysis, the featural make-up of the four IS markers might be represented as—respectively—[Δ, NEW], [Δ, CNTR], [Δ, EXCL], and [Δ, ADD].

This proposal analogizes the discourse markers to a functional lexical class, such as complementizers or prepositions. For example, there are certain ways in which the English prepositions *in*, *on*, and *through* pattern together. As such, they should be modeled as belonging to a single syntactic class (P). At the same time, each preposition expresses specific lexical information, so it needs to be associated with a unique feature. Importantly, these two desiderata can be fulfilled by representing prepositions as feature bundles, e. g. [P, IN], [P, ON], and [P, THROUGH], without recourse to feature hierarchy.

The analogy between classes of functional heads (such as prepositions) and the A'ingae discourse markers, however, has its limits. Concretely, the prepositions (and other parts of speech) are distinguished as a syntactic category specifically because they occupy a unique syntactic position and are related to other prepositions paradigmatically—this is to say, they are mutually exclusive. For example, an English PP may be headed by the preposition *in* or *on*, but not both.

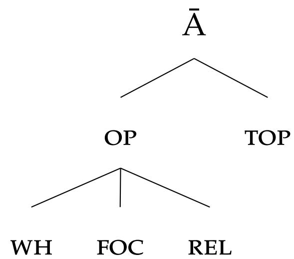
The A'ingae discourse markers are not mutually exclusive. The exclusive focus *-yi* EXCL can be followed by the additive focus *-ʔkhe* ADD, and the focus markers can be followed *-ta* NEW or *-ja* CNTR. This shows that the discourse markers are introduced by different syntactic heads. Yet, each discourse marker triggers the realization *-ʔ* when linearly adjacent to a TP. This means that the *ʔ*-trigger is not a syntactic category, but rather by a feature that the discourse markers have in common ([δ]), despite not sharing a single head. As such, the Δ-category feature analysis is not adopted.

7.5 *Ā-geometry analysis*

Finally, I discuss an analysis which invokes a geometric relationship among the discourse markers, but attributes their commonalities to a different superordinate feature.

Specifically, I observe that topic and focus also figure in feature geometries such as (60), where [Ā] dominates [TOP], [FOC] (and hence presumably also [NEW], [CNTR], [EXCL], and [ADD]), as well as other features. As such, one might ask if *-ʔ* could alternatively be analyzed as the realization of T° when linearly adjacent to [Ā] (i. e. T ⟷ *-ʔ* / _ Ā).

(60) Ā-FEATURE GEOMETRY (Baier, 2018, p. 45, adapted from Aravind, 2018, p. 19)



Notably, this alternative analysis predicts that T° should be realized as *-ʔ* when adjacent to suffixes expressing not only topic and focus, but also other Ā-features, such as [WH] or [REL].

This prediction is not easy to test because overt morphemes which express Ā-features—other than *-ta* NEW, *-ja* CNTR, *-yi* EXCL, and *-ʔkhe* ADD—(almost) never appear to the immediate right of a verb-internal T°. For example, WH-bearing constituents are realized as independent morphosyntactic words, and the language lacks overt relativizers altogether.

One morphosyntactic configuration which may be seen as a possible test for the Ā-hypothesis involves verbal WH-movement. In A'ingae content questions, the WH-word is obligatorily fronted, and a second-position clitic must appear to its immediate right (Dąbkowski, 2022). As such, Dąbkowski (2023b) analyzes the A'ingae P2 clitics as C-heads which trigger WH-movement.

In addition, A'ingae has a question verb *mikun* 'do what' which—like all other WH-words—must appear right before the P2 clitic. Since P2 clitics trigger WH-movement, they presumably have the uninterpretable [uWH] feature. Since the WH-verb *mikun* 'do what' can be inflected with situation-level morphology (such as the plural subject *-ʔfa* PLS and irrealis *-ya* IRR), it is a TP. After fronting, the P2 clitic forms one morphosyntactic (and phonological) word with the WH-verb, creating a configuration where T° is adjacent to a [uWH]-carrying morpheme (61). The span stretching from T° through the P2 clitic is underlined. Moved constituents and checked features are ~~stricken through~~.

(61) WH-VERB WITH A P2 CLITIC
[*míkun-ʔfa-ya-∅*]$_{\text{TP}}$ *=tsû*$_{[\cancel{\text{uWH}}]}$ ~~*míkun-ʔfa-ya*~~$_{[\text{WH}]}$
do what-PLS-IRR-T =3
"What will they do?" (2025-11-06(1)_jxm)

As seen in (61), the T-head is not realized as a glottal stop despite its adjacency to [~~uWH~~]. The interpretation of this fact depends on whether checked features, such [~~uWH~~], can be active at the point of allomorph selection. If one assumes that uninterpretable (checked) features can trigger allomorphy, the case observed in (61) counts as evidence against adopting the Ā-feature geometry of (60). If, on the other hand, checked features are inert for purposes of determining allomorphy, the structure in (61) is irrelevant to choosing between the two alternatives.

In either case, while the A'ingae data may not provide conclusive evidence with regard to the role of features such as [WH] or [REL], both analyses ($\text{T} \longleftrightarrow$ *-ʔ* / _ δ as well as $\text{T} \longleftrightarrow$ *-ʔ* / _ $\bar{\text{A}}$) require discourse features to be organized in a geometrical hierarchy, with one higher-order feature dominating all the maximal ones.

More broadly, I observe that Ā-feature geometries, such as the one in (60), have been mostly motivated by data from languages where different Ā-carrying constituents pattern together in some way, e. g. with respect to long-distance WH-licensing (Aravind, 2018), morphological impoverishment (Baier, 2018), or Ā-movement. In A'ingae, it is not clear that the WH-feature has anything in common with the language's discourse markers. For example, the A'ingae WH-constituents undergo movement to Spec,CP (Dąbkowski, 2022, 2023b), but discourse-marked constituents do not (see §3). This raises the possibility that the Ā-feature geometry of (60) is not motivated for A'ingae.

8 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

In this paper, I have described and analyzed the conditions under which a glottal stop *-ʔ* appears before IS morphemes. Specifically, I have shown that the glottal stop is realized only if a discourse morpheme is attached directly to a TP, and can be analyzed as the spell-out of T° when linearly adjacent to the superordinate discourse feature [δ]. The proposed analysis has several theoretical implications.

First, it draws on the notion of *discourse differentiation*, proposed by Mikkelsen (2015) and formalized as [δ] by Bossi and Diercks (2019). By showing that all of the A'ingae IS morphemes pattern alike in triggering allomorphy of T°, the paper provides novel morphological evidence for a geometric arrangement of discourse features, with [δ] inherited by all the maximal ones. In doing so, the present study contributes to the broader research program on the geometric arrangement of morphosyntactic features (e. g. Harley and Ritter, 2002; Béjar and Rezac, 2009; Preminger, 2011), and of Ā-features in particular (e. g. Aravind, 2018; Baier, 2018; Baclawski, 2019).

Second, the contextual realization of *-ʔ* provides support for less restrictive theories of allomorph selection. In Section 6, the glottal stop *-ʔ* has been shown to be a realization of T° when immediately followed by a discourse morpheme. Under this analysis, the allomorphy of T° is conditioned by an outer morpheme (i. e. a morpheme attaching *after* T°). This is in direct violation of the Peripherality Constraint (Carstairs, 1987, p. 196; Kiparsky, 2021, p. 392), which states allomorphy can be triggered only inside-out. The Peripherality Constraint is quoted in (62).

(62) PERIPHERALITY CONSTRAINT (Kiparsky, 2021, p. 392 from Carstairs, 1987, p. 193)
"The realization of a property P may be sensitive inwards, i. e. to a property realized more centrally in the word-form (that is, closer in linear sequence to the root) but not outwards to an individual property realized more peripherally (further from the root)."

The proposed analysis is, however, compatible with less restrictive views of allomorphy that allow for outward-looking selection. Outward-looking allomorph selection has been shown to be necessary for a number of languages, including Itelmen (Chukotko-Kamchatkan; Bobaljik, 2000), Luganda (Bantu; Hyman, 2015), Nez Perce (Sahaptian; Deal and Wolf, 2017), and others.[22]

Third, by referring to independently motivated morphosyntactic features (such as [T] and [δ]) and utilizing widely accepted mechanisms (such as *pruning*; Embick, 2010, 2015), a DM analysis can model the somewhat complex distribution of the A'ingae *-ʔ* with a single vocabulary item. This reduction of an empirically novel pattern to a combination of analytical tools needed to account for unrelated phenomena in unrelated languages bears out the predictions of syntax-centric models of morphology in a novel way.

At the same time, the A'ingae *-ʔ* T remains a typological rarum. Its distribution is abstract and difficult to state in non-theoretical terms. Using relatively descriptive language, the glottal stop *-ʔ* could be said to mark the morphosyntactic boundary between "predicate inflection" and discourse-level marking. However, without invoking verb-internal syntactic structure, the notion of "predicate inflection" is difficult to state precisely,[23] and the

22 If, on the other hand, the analysis were flipped on its head, and the glottal stop *-ʔ* analyzed as a spell-out of [δ] in the presence of a linearly adjacent (and preceding) T-head, i. e. [δ] ⟷ *-ʔ* / T _, the Peripherality Constraint (62) would be satisfied. However, since T is clearly a syntactic (and syntactically relevant) feature, the revised analysis would run afoul of Bobaljik's (2000, pp. 2–3) second generalization (iiib).

(iii) BOBALJIK'S (2000, PP. 2–3) GENERALIZATIONS
a. *"[A]llomorphy conditioned by more peripheral morphemes/features is only sensitive to morpho-**syntactic** (i. e., syntactically relevant) features (such as tense and agreement)[;]*
b. *"inwards-sensitive allomorphy ... is conditioned by morpho-(**phono-**)logical features such as class marking and other (syntactically irrelevant) diacritics[.]"* (emphasis Bobaljik's)

Additionally, note that since the IS morphemes all inherit from [δ], the suffixes *-ta*, *-ja*, *-yi*, *-ʔkhe* already spell out [δ]. As such, adopting this alternative—where *-ʔ* is also a realization of [δ]—would involve multiple exponence.

23 For example, on one hand, no particular overt verbal morpheme is required for the glottal stop *-ʔ* to be realized. On the other hand, the glottal stop is not realized on verbs overtly (co)subordinated with

requirement on "discourse-level marking" can be satisfied by one of several semantically related suffixes. In other words, the A'ingae pattern highlights the value of highly abstract work in revealing the distribution of otherwise puzzling morphology.

Finally, the present proposal makes a non-obvious descriptive claim related to conditional morphology: Even though same-subject antecedents are seen most often with the preglottalized *-ʔta* and *-ʔja*, neither sequence is analyzed as contributing the conditional meaning (63a).[24] Rather, the glottal stop *-ʔ* is proposed to be a syntactically conditioned spell-out of the T-head, the discourse marker is taken to contribute its regular discourse meaning, and the same-subject conditional morpheme is taken to actually be phonologically silent (63b).

(63) ANALYSIS INFORMS GLOSSING

a. INCORRECT GLOSSING

afa-khú-ʔja sumbú-ya =ngi
*speak-RCPR-IF.SS leave-IRR =1
"If I argue, I will leave." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

b. CORRECT GLOSSING

afa-khú-ʔ-∅-ja sumbú-ya =ngi
speak-RCPR-T-IF.SS-CNTR leave-IRR =1
"If I argue, I will leave." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

This reiterates the important—though perhaps uncontroversial (e. g. Kuhn, 1962; Hanson, 1979; Mendikoetxea, 2003; Bach, 2004; Dryer, 2006)—point that language description and analysis are not two separate endeavors, and that they must mutually inform each other.

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morphemes other than the infinitive *-ye* INF. Yet, notably, this disjunctive list of conditions can easily be dispensed with by simply saying that the glottal stop *-ʔ* is a spell-out of T°.

24 In this, the present analysis differs from some previous proposals (e. g. Dąbkowski, 2021b,c, 2024b), which make the mistake of presenting *-ʔta* and *-ʔja* as morphologically atomic.

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A APPENDIX

A.1 *Word order and P2 clitics*

There is no particular position in a sentence that the IS-marked constituents must occupy. For example, while new topics are often the first constituent in a sentence, non-initial topics, including new topics (64a) and contrastive topics (64b), are also grammatical and found in natural corpora. Multiple IS-marked constituents (including constituents carrying the same marker) may appear per clause (64).

(64) MULTIPLE TOPIC PER CLAUSE

a. MULTIPLE NEW TOPICS *-TA* NEW

ké?i=ta	*=ti=ki*	*séje?pa=ve=ta*	*á?mbian-?fa?*
2PL=NEW	=YNQ=2	poison=ACC2=NEW	have-PLS

"Do you have poison?" (Quenamá, 1992, pp. 21, 57; `2024-06-10(1)_mll`)

b. MULTIPLE CONTRASTIVE TOPICS *-JA* CNTR

tayúpi=ja	*jungáesû=ma*	*séma-?jen-?-jan*	*tsé-?thi=nga*	*=tsû*	*má?kaen*
long ago=CNTR	something=ACC	work-IPFV-T-CNTR	STA-PLC=DAT	=3	somehow

jungáesû=ma	*khá?na-sa?ne-jan*	*íyû?û-pa*	*kúndase-?fa*
something=ACC	steal-APPR-CNTR	scold-SS	tell-PLS

"In the old days, when (young people) were working on something (for someone else), (their fathers) would caution them not to steal anything from there." (Criollo and Blanco Pisabarro, 1992, pp. 43, 90; `2024-03-04(1)_sia`)

A'ingae topic markers interact with second-position clitics. A'ingae has five sentence-level clitics which encode the person feature of the matrix subject (first person *=ngi* 1, second person *=ki* 2, third person *=tsû* 3), evidentiality (reportative *=te* RPRT), and illocutionary force (polar interrogative *=ti* YNQ). The clitics are prototypically optional in matrix clauses, disallowed in subordinate clauses, and—when present—linearized after the first clausal constituent, i. e. in the second position. (These properties of the A'ingae P2 clitics can be derived by analyzing them as matrix-clausal C-heads. For more on the P2 clitics, see Dąbkowski, 2023b.)

However, the IS markers may cause deviations from those prototypical patterns. For example, although otherwise generally optional, a second-position clitic is preferred when a constituent marked with the new topic *-ta* NEW is present (65).

(65) P2 CLITIC PREFERRED AFTER NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW

a. NEW TOPIC WITHOUT PREGLOTTALIZATION *-TA*

áin=nda ?(=tsû) tsâi-ye atésû
dog=NEW =3 bite-INF know
"The dog bites." (2024-05-27(2)_sia)

b. NEW TOPIC WITH PREGLOTTALIZATION *-ʔTA*

án-ʔ-nda ?(=ngi) khipuéʔsû-ya-mbi
eat-T-NEW =1 hungry-IRR-NEG
"If I eat, I won't be hungry." (2024-05-27(2)_sia)

Moreover, the P2 clitics are ungrammatical immediately after constituents marked with the contrastive topic *-ja* CNTR (Fischer and Hengeveld, 2023) (66). These patterns hold regardless of whether (65b, 66b) or not (65a, 66a) the IS morpheme is preceded by the glottal stop *-ʔ* T.

(66) P2 CLITIC DISALLOWED AFTER CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR

a. CONTRASTIVE TOPIC WITHOUT PREGLOTTALIZATION *-JA*

**áʔtse=ja (*=tsû) tsáʔu=nga (=tsû) káʔni*
hummingbird=CNTR =3 house=DAT =3 enter
"A hummingbird entered the house." (2024-04-03(1)_sia)

b. CONTRASTIVE TOPIC WITH PREGLOTTALIZATION *-ʔJA*

afa-khú-ʔ-ja (=ngi) sumbú-ya (=ngi)*
speak-RCPR-T-CNTR =1 leave-IRR =1
"If I argue, I will leave." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

A.2 *Additional examples*

(67) USES OF THE EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL

a. *túya án-ʔjen-mba-yi =ki jí-mbi?*
still eat-IPFV-SS-EXCL =2 come-NEG
"You didn't come just because you were still eating?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

b. *tsá-ʔkan-si =tsû tíse-ʔsû áʔi=yi=ja máʔkaen fíʔthi-pa ávû kíniʔjin=ma*
ANA-SA-DS =3 3SG-ATTR person=EXCL=CNTR somehow kill-SS fish tree=ACC
júkhaningae tsún-ña-ʔchu-ve-ja tsún-ʔfa
for later do-IRR-EN-ACC2-CNTR do-PLS
"Because of that, those very same ones had to kill, ensuring the survival of the fish tree." (Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 25; 2024-06-07(1)_mll)

c. *junguésû=yi =tsû náʔen=ni kánse?*
what=EXCL =3 river=LOC live
"What is it that lives in the river?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

(68) Uses of the additive focus -*ʔkhe* add

a. *tíse =tsû kínse-tshi túyaʔkaen tsúve ínjan-ʔjen-ʔchu-ʔkhe ñú-tshi*
3sg =3 healthy-pa and head like-ipfv-en-add good-pa
"S/he is healthy and mentally well." (`2025-07-22(1)_mll`)

b. *kúndase khû̂i, tíse dyú-ʔni-ʔkhe*
tell lie down 3sg fear-if.ds-add
"While lying (on the ground, the severed head) talked (to him/her), even though s/he was scared." (Chica Umenda, 1980, p. 26; `2024-03-04(1)_sia`)

c. *kánse =tsû setsa-yé-mbe-ʔkhe*
live =3 infect-pass-adv.neg-add
"S/he does not get sick either." (`2025-07-17(1)_mll`)

(69) Licit combinations of informational structural markers

a. exclusive focus -*yi* excl + additive focus -*ʔkhe* add
tsá-ʔma tsé-ki kúse ni fae ávû=ve=yi=ʔkhe índi-ʔfa-mbi =ngi
ana-frst sta-drn night neither one fish=acc2=excl=add catch-pls-neg =1
"But that night we did not catch even a single fish."
(John 21:3; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

b. exclusive focus -*yi* excl + new topic -*ta* new
tsá-ʔka-en kánse-ʔfa-ʔ-yi-ta =ki ñuáʔme shaká-ʔfa-ya-mbi
ana-sa-adv live-pls-T-excl-new =2 truly lack-pls-irr-neg
"Only if you live like this, you will truly not lack (anything)."
(Thessalonians 4:12; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

c. exclusive focus -*yi* excl + contrastive topic -*ja* cntr
tsá-ʔkan-si =tsû tíse-ʔsû áʔi=yi=ja máʔkaen fíʔthi-pa ávû kíniʔjin=ma
ana-sa-ds =3 3sg-attr person=excl=cntr somehow kill-ss fish tree=acc
júkhaningae tsún-ña-ʔchu-ve-ja tsún-ʔfa
for later do-irr-en-acc2-cntr do-pls
"Because of that, those very same ones had to kill, ensuring the survival of the fish tree." (Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 25; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

d. additive focus -*ʔkhe* add + new topic -*ta* new
ké=ʔkhe=ta =ti=ki tsa áʔi=ma shúndu-ʔsû-mbi?
2sg=add=new =ynq=2 ana person=acc accompany-sn-neg
"Art not thou also one of this man's disciples?"
(John 18:17; `2024-06-07(1)_mll`)

(70) Plain realization on non-predicates

a. pronoun + contrastive topic -*ja* cntr
tíse=ja ñuáʔme ke pû́she =tsû
3sg=cntr truly 2sg wife =3
"Behold, of a surety she is thy wife." (Genesis 26:9; `2024-06-10(1)_mll`)

b. WH-PHRASE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL
junguésû=yi =tsû náʔen=ni kánse?
what=EXCL =3 river=LOC live
"What is it that lives in the river?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

c. ADJECTIVE + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
áʔta-tshi-a=ta =ti fáeʔngae sínthia=iʔkhû kánʔjen-ña?
day-PA-ADN=NEW =YNQ together darkness=INS be.ANM-IRR
"And what communion hath light with darkness?"
(2 Corinthians 6:14; 2024-06-10(1)_mll)

d. INFLECTED NOUN + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
májan =tsû cofán=ndekhû=ja?
who =3 Cofán=PL.H=CNTR
"Who are the Cofán?"
(Blaser and Chica Umenda, 2008, p. 10; 2024-06-10(1)_mll)

e. CASE-MARKED PHRASE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL
áʔi=nga enthínge=ve=yi áfe
person=DAT half=ACC2=EXCL give
"(He) gave the (other) half to the man."
(Borman and Criollo, 1990, p. 87; 2024-06-10(1)_mll)

(71) PREGLOTTALIZED REALIZATION ON INFINITIVES WITH -*YE* INF

a. *YE*-SUBJECT + -ʔ T + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
án-ñe-ʔ-nda =tsû injénge-ʔchu
eat-INF-T-NEW =3 needed-EN
"Eating is important." (2024-05-27(2)_sia)

b. *YE*-ARGUMENT + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
atésû =ngi guáʔthi-an-ñe-ʔ-jan
know =1 boil-CAUS-INF-T-CNTR
"I (habitually) boil." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

c. SAME-SUBJECT *YE*-RATIONALE + -ʔ T + -*YI* EXCL + -*JA* CNTR
jí =ngi afa-khú-ye-ʔ-yi-ja
come =1 speak-RCPR-INF-T-EXCL-CNTR
"I only came (here) to argue." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

d. DIFFERENT-SUBJECT *YE*-RATIONALE + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
tíse =tsû avûja-en (kûintsû) kúfe-ʔje-ye-ʔ-ja
3SG =3 rejoice-CAUS PURP.DS play-IPFV-INF-T-CNTR
"S/he encouraged them to be playing." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

e. *YE*-HORTATIVE + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL
jingésû kíʔan-ʔfa-ye-ʔ-yi
HORT strong-PLS-INF-T-EXCL
"Let's just be strong!" (2024-06-25(1)_mll)

f. SAME-SUBJECT *YE*-RATIONALE + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
afa-khú-ye-ʔkhe-ta =ngi áʔingae=ma atésû-ʔje
speak-RCPR-INF-ADD-NEW =1 A'ingae=ACC learn-IPFV
"I am studying A'ingae also so that I can argue (with people)."
(2025-01-20(1)_mll)

(72) PLAIN REALIZATION ON SAME-SUBJECT CLAUSES WITH *-PA* SS

a. *PA*-PREDICATE
ápi=ma píʔpi-pa ísû
clay=ACC mold-SS take
"(S/he) made a clay pot and picked it up."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1977, p. 13; 2024-02-20(1)_sia)

b. *PA*-PREDICATE + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
afé-ya =ti fae regálo=ve ké=nga ke yáya-pa-ja?
give-IRR =YNQ one gift=ACC2 2SG=DAT 2SG dad-SS-CNTR
"Will he give you a gift because he's your dad?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

c. *PA*-PREDICATE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
túya án-ʔjen-mba-yi =ki jí-mbi?
still eat-IPFV-SS-EXCL =2 come-NEG
"You didn't come just because you were still eating?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

d. *PA*-PREDICATE + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD
amphí-pa-ʔkhe =ti=ki tsífu=ja báthi-ʔchu-mbi?
fall-SS-ADD =YNQ=2 neck=CNTR dislocate-EN-NEG
"Did you injure your neck also by falling?" (2024-06-06(1)_mll)

(73) PLAIN REALIZATION ON DIFFERENT-SUBJECT CLAUSES WITH *-SI* DS

a. *SI*-PREDICATE
arápa pá-si =tsû ísû
chicken die-DS =3 take
"The chicken died and s/he picked it up."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1977, p. 13; 2024-02-20(1)_sia)

b. *SI*-PREDICATE + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
tíse ke yáya-si-ta =ti=ki isû́-ya fae regálo=ma?
3SG 2SG dad-DS-NEW =YNQ=2 get-IRR one gift=ACC
"Will you get a gift from him because he's your dad?" (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

c. *SI*-PREDICATE + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
kéʔi atesû́-ʔfa-mbi-si-ja kéʔi=nga teváen-mbi =ngi
2PL know-PLS-NEG-DS-CNTR 2PL=DAT write-NEG =1
"I do not write to you because you do not know (the truth)."
(1 John 2:21; 2024-06-10(1)_mll)

d. *si*-PREDICATE + ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔkhe* ADD
píyi kán-si-ʔkhe =ti íñe?
turn look-DS-ADD =YNQ hurt
"Does it hurt also when you turn (your head)?" (2024-06-06(1)_mll)

(74) PLAIN REALIZATION ON APPREHENSIONAL CLAUSES WITH -*SAʔNE* APPR

a. *saʔne*-AVERTIVE PRECAUTIONING
sinthí-mbe-ʔ-yi tsû kán-ña-ʔchu kháse anjámpa tshán-saʔne
blow-ADV.NEG-T-EXCL =3 AUX-IRR-EN again blood bleed-APPR
"You should not blow your nose, so that you don't make it bleed again."
(Pederson and Cooper, 1982, pp. 68–69; 2024-02-20(1)_sia)

b. *saʔne*-IN-CASE PRECAUTIONING + NEW TOPIC -*ta* NEW
ûnjin tûi-saʔne-nda =ngi bûthú-ya
rain rain-APPR-NEW =1 run-IRR
"I will run in case it rains." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

c. *saʔne*-COMPLEMENT OF *fear* + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*yi* EXCL
tíseʔpa ña yayá-ndekhû-ʔfa-saʔne-ñi =ngi dyúju
3PL 1SG dad-PL.H-PLS-APPR-EXCL =1 be afraid
"I fear only that they are my parents." (2024-06-11(1)_mll)

d. *saʔne*-AVERTIVE PRECAUTIONING + ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔkhe* ADD
índi-saʔne-ʔkhe =ngi bûthú-ya
catch-APPR-ADD =1 run-IRR
"I will run also so that (s/he) doesn't catch (me)." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

(75) PLAIN REALIZATION ON TENTATIVE CLAUSES WITH -*KHEN* TENT

a. *khen*-PREDICATE
seʔjé-khen =ngi tsún-ʔjen
cure-TENT =1 do-IPFV
"I am trying to cure." (2022-07-01(1)_jxm)

b. *khen*-PREDICATE + NEW TOPIC -*ta* NEW
athe-yé-khen-nda =ngi tsún-ʔjen
see-PASS-TENT-NEW =1 do-IPFV
"I am trying to be seen." (2024-06-11(2)_mll)

c. *khen*-PREDICATE + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*ja* CNTR
inʔján-khen-jan iyíkhu-ʔje =ngi
believe-TENT-CNTR fight-IPFV =1
"I am wrestling to believe." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

d. *khen*-PREDICATE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*yi* EXCL
iʔná-khen-ñi =ngi vána-ʔjen
cry-TENT-EXCL =1 suffer-IPFV
"I am struggling only to cry." (2025-07-17(1)_mll)

e. KHEN-PREDICATE + ADDITIVE FOCUS -ʔKHE ADD

athé-khen-ʔkhe =ngi tsún-ʔjen
see-TENT-ADD =1 do-IPFV
"I am also trying to see." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

(76) PREGLOTTALIZED REALIZATION ON SAME-SUBJECT CONDITIONALS

a. UNMARKED ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -YI EXCL

thési=ma afáse-ʔje-ʔ-yi =ngi bûthú-ya
jaguar=ACC criticize-IPFV-T-EXCL =1 run-IRR
"I will run criticizing only the jaguar." (2024-06-06(2)_mll)

b. ANTECEDENT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -YI EXCL + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -JA CNTR

thési=ma áfase-ʔ-yi-ja bûthú-ya =ngi
jaguar=ACC criticize-T-EXCL-CNTR run-IRR =1
"Only if I criticize a jaguar, I will run." (2024-06-06(2)_mll)

(77) PLAIN REALIZATION ON DIFFERENT-SUBJECT CONDITIONALS WITH -ʔNI IF.DS

a. ʔNI-ANTECEDENT

khén íngi sû́-ʔje-ʔni fáeʔkhu-e-ta púʔtaen-ʔfa-ʔya
THUS 1PL say-IPFV-IF.DS one-ADV-NEW shoot-PLS-ASSR
"While we were saying this, there was one gunshot."
(Quenamá, 1992, pp. 25, 42; 2025-01-20(1)_mll)

b. ʔNI-ANTECEDENT + NEW TOPIC -TA NEW

ñá náʔen=nga kháya-ʔje-ʔni-nda =tsû tíseʔpa séma-ʔjen-ʔfa
1SG river=DAT swim-IPFV-IF.DS-NEW =3 3PL work-IPFV-PLS
"When I am swimming in the river, they are working." (2022-07-01(2)_sia)

c. ʔNI-ANTECEDENT + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -JA CNTR

ránde=ʔni=jan chavá-ya =ngi
large=IF.DS=CNTR buy-IRR =1
"If it's large, I'll buy it." (2024-06-10(1)_mll)

d. ʔNI-ANTECEDENT + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -YI EXCL

thési=ma áthe-ʔfa-ʔni-ñi =tsû bû́thu
jaguar=ACC see-PLS-IF.DS-EXCL =3 run
"As soon as they saw a jaguar, (another person) ran." (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

e. ʔNI-ANTECEDENT + ADDITIVE FOCUS -ʔKHE ADD

kúndase khû́i, tíse dyú-ʔni-ʔkhe
tell lie down 3SG fear-IF.DS-ADD
"While lying (on the ground, the severed head) talked (to him/her), even though s/he was scared." (Chica Umenda, 1980, p. 26; 2024-03-04(1)_sia)

(78) MINIMAL (ʔ)*TA*-PAIR ON AN ADJECTIVE

a. ARGUMENT + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
ránde=ta =tsû jí-ya-mbi
large=NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG
"(The) large (one) will not come." (2025-01-20(1)_mll)

b. PREDICATE + -ʔ T + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
ránde=ʔ=ta =tsû jí-ya-mbi
large=T=NEW =3 come-IRR-NEG
"If (s/he) is large, (s/he) will not come." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

(79) MINIMAL (ʔ)*JA*-PAIR ON A NOUN

a. ARGUMENT + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
yáya=ja ñá=ma íyûʔû-ya =tsû
dad=CNTR 1SG=ACC scold-IRR =3
"(My) dad will advise me." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

b. PREDICATE + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC -*JA* CNTR
yáya=ʔ=ja ñá=ma íyûʔû-ya =tsû
dad=T=CNTR 1SG=ACC scold-IRR =3
"If (he)'s a dad, he'll advise me." (2024-06-20(2)_mll)

(80) PLAIN REALIZATION ON NOMINALIZATIONS

a. *ʔSÛ*-NOMINALIZATION + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
ké=ma atesi-án-ʔsû-ta =ti Chíga éthi=ma ñuñá-ña-ʔchu impuésto=ma afepuén-ʔjen?
2SG=ACC learn-CAUS-SN-NEW =YNQ god house=ACC make-IRR-EN tax=ACC pay-IPFV
"Does your teacher (not) pay the temple tax?"
(Matthew 17:24; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

b. *ʔFA*-NOMINALIZATION + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL
fae putáen-ʔfa-yi khuángiʔkhu-e fíʔthi thúfi=ma
one shoot-LAT-EXCL two-ADV kill parrot=ACC
"(I) killed two parrots (with) one shot."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1982b, p. 37; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

c. *ʔTHI*-NOMINALIZATION + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS -*YI* EXCL + ADDITIVE FOCUS -*ʔKHE* ADD
ni fae teváen-ʔthi-yi-ʔkhe pasá-ya-mbi
neither one write-PLC-EXCL-ADD pass-IRR-NEG
"One tittle (of the law) shall not fail." (Luke 16:17; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

d. *KHÛ*-NOMINALIZATION + NEW TOPIC -*TA* NEW
dű̂ʔshû tise máma=me rúʔnda-ya-khû-ta =tsû ránde
child 3SG mom=ACC2 wait-IRR-BND-NEW =3 large
"The room where a child will wait for their mom is large." (2025-07-17(1)_mll)

e. *ʔCHU*-NOMINALIZATION + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
tsá=ʔma séfa=ni=ʔsû íngi túya áthe-mbi-ʔchu-a-ja tsángae =tsû jinchú-ya
ANA=FRST sky=LOC=ATTR 1PL still see-NEG-EN-ADN-CNTR forever =3 be.INA-RMNS-IRR
"But what is unseen in the heavens is eternal."
(2 Corinthians 4:18; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

f. *ʔCHU*-NOMINALIZATION + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD
tíse =tsû kínse-tshi túyaʔkaen tsúve ínjan-ʔjen-ʔchu-ʔkhe ñú-tshi
3SG =3 healthy-PA and head like-IPFV-EN-ADD good-PA
"S/he is healthy and mentally well." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

(81) PLAIN REALIZATION ON ADVERBS

a. ROOT ADVERB + NEW TOPIC *-TA* NEW
káni-nda =tsû án
yesterday-NEW =3 eat
"S/he ate yesterday." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

b. *E*-ADVERB + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
tsínkun-ʔjen =tsû éga-e-ja
behave-IPFV =3 bad-ADV-CNTR
"S/he's behaving badly." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

c. *TSHE*-ADVERB + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
gíya-tshe-yi =tsû áʔmbian-ña-ʔchu
clean-ADV.PA-EXCL =3 have-IRR-EN
"(One) must always keep (it) clean." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

(82) PLAIN REALIZATION ON ADVERBIALIZED NOMINALIZATION WITH *-ʔCHU-E* EN-ADV

a. SAME-SUBJECT *ʔCHUE*-RATIONALE
áʔi=ja yusháva=ma kaváyu áyaʔfa=nga búta-en máni
person=CNTR iron=ACC horse mouth=DAT mouth-CAUS where
já-ya-ʔchu-ve tansi-án-ña-ʔchu-e
go-IRR-EN-ACC2 be straight-CAUS-IRR-EN-ADV
"When we put bits into the mouths of horses to make them obey us, we can turn the whole animal." (James 3:3; 2025-07-17(1)_mll)

b. SAME-SUBJECT *ʔCHUE*-RATIONALE + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
séma-ʔjen =ngi ánkheʔsû=ma áʔmbian-ña-ʔchu-e-ja
work-IPFV =1 food=ACC have-IRR-EN-ADV-CNTR
"I'm working to have food." (2025-08-21(1)_mll)

c. *ʔCHUE*-HORTATIVE + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
jínge panzá-ya-ʔchu-e-ja
HORT hunt-IRR-EN-ADV-CNTR
"Let's hunt!" (2025-08-21(1)_mll)

d. *ʔCHUE*-DEPICTIVE + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
iyúfa-ʔkan-ʔchu-e-yi =tsû súmbu-ʔje
worm-SA-EN-ADV-EXCL =3 leave-IPFV
"It's coming out only like worms." (2025-08-12(1)_jxm)

e. *ʔCHUE*-ARGUMENT + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD
tíse =tsû panzá-ya-ʔchu-e-ʔkhe atésû
3SG =3 hunt-IRR-EN-ADV-ADD know
"S/he also knows how to hunt." (2025-08-21(1)_mll)

(83) PREGLOTTALIZED REALIZATION ON NEGATIVE ADVERBIAL CLAUSES WITH *-MBE* ADV.NEG

a. NEGATIVE CIRCUMSTANCE *MBE*-ADJUNCT
simbá-ʔma án-mbi-si así-mbe jí
hook-FRST eat-NEG-DS fish-ADV.NEG come
"(I) was fishing with a hook, but (the fish) didn't take (the bait, so I) came (back home) without having caught (anything)."
(Borman and Chica Umenda, 1980, p. 42; 2025-07-22(1)_mll)

b. NEGATIVE CIRCUMSTANCE *MBE*-ADJUNCT + -ʔ T + CONTRASTIVE TOPIC *-JA* CNTR
kánse =tsû asitháen-ʔjen-mbe-ʔ-ja
live =3 worry-IPFV-ADV.NEG-T-CNTR
"S/he lives without a care in the world." (2025-07-22(1)_mll)

c. *MBE*-ARGUMENT + -ʔ T + EXCLUSIVE FOCUS *-YI* EXCL
sinthí-mbe-ʔ-yi tsû kán-ña-ʔchu khâse anjámpa tshán-saʔne
blow-ADV.NEG-T-EXCL =3 AUX-IRR-EN again blood bleed-APPR
"You should not blow your nose, so that you don't make it bleed again."
(Pederson and Cooper, 1982, pp. 68–69; 2024-02-20(1)_sia)

d. NEGATIVE CIRCUMSTANCE *MBE*-ADJUNCT + ADDITIVE FOCUS *-ʔKHE* ADD
kánse =tsû setsa-yé-mbe-ʔkhe
live =3 infect-PASS-ADV.NEG-ADD
"S/he does not get sick either." (2025-07-17(1)_mll)